

Blades of Ether



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As far as the eye can see, the world of Arlest is blanketed in a sea of clouds. One would expect to fall straight through to the foggy depths, yet it has the buoyancy of water. Atop this sea, far above the long-dead civilizations buried beneath, float gigantic beings known as Titans. Titans come in many sizes, some massive enough to hold entire countries on their backs, others barely large enough for a single person to live on. Their forms, too, vary greatly, resembling all manner of beings, some even appearing eerily human. Although the Titans are many in number, the Cloud Sea is vaster and emptier still, so travel between living landmasses remains a non-trivial task.

At the center of the sea lies the World Tree, a massive plant-like spire that reaches far higher than anyone has been able to observe. This huge structure can be seen from miles around, making it a vital and uniquely unmoving landmark. The Cloud Sea stops a mile shy of the tree, giving way to a perilous gap, the Great Void, into which falling would surely be fatal. While explorers have tried to bridge this expanse and climb the botanic babel, none are known to have ever returned, unless you believe the claims of a handful of opportunists looking to make quick fortunes.

The societies living on Titan-back vary wildly. Communication between Titans is difficult, and the further apart two are, the harder it gets. It is said that there are almost as many cultures, levels of technology, languages, climates, and sapient species as there are Titans. This is, of course, probably impossible, as not every Titan is suitable for a whole society to live on, but since no one has ever visited every Titan, no one has ever been able to disprove it. In fact, some Titans are so elusive that they reside below the Cloud Sea, entire societies thriving within them.

There is only one thing that every Titan-based society holds in common: Blades. Titans naturally produce cores, glowing gemstones that house slumbering etheric souls. When an organic being takes up one of these monochrome crystals, the ether within flows through them, creating an explosion of color and energy that only some can weather. Beings with this potential can resonate with the latent Blade, anchoring its energy, waking it and revealing its true color and form. Those who forge Blades are known as Bearers, and a Bearer's bond is for life.

Blades, etheric in constitution, need the force of the connection they share with their Bearer to stay awakened. Bearers, too, draw strength from the bond, gaining elemental powers and preternatural etheric ability. The further apart Blade and Bearer are, the weaker the Blade grows, but no matter the distance their bond will never break.

Only upon the death of their Bearer do Blades lose their bond, reverting them to their core form where they wait in colorless slumber to be forged once again. Without a bond to sustain the Blade's mind, all of their memories are lost, and they remember nothing of their previous lives and bonds when they are reawakened. Although truly killing a Blade is difficult — cores are harder than diamond, especially when the Blade dwells within — many consider the severing of a bond to be the end of both Bearer and Blade.

Blades and Bearers are powerful entities, and can have a massive effect on the world around them. Everything lies in the wake of their journeys, their aspirations, their bonds, and their ideals. The question now, Bearer or Blade, is what kind of impact will you and your partner have?

Blades of Ether

For more information, to download a digitally fillable character sheet, or to leave us a good review, visit gears.link/blades.

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For a plain text version of this rulebook designed with visual accessibility and screen reader-friendliness in mind, visit gears.link/blades/accessible.

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Chapter 1: Bearers, Blades, and Beyond

Throughout the eras, there have been countless journeys across the Cloud Sea. Some are still told as legend, while others have been long buried beneath the thick fog. Some have forever changed the lives of every being who will ever live, and some have fizzled out without even the smallest spark. It may surprise you, though, how little an adventure's notoriety has to do with its impact.

Welcome to *Blades of Ether*, a tabletop roleplaying game about the escapades of eternally-linked Blades, beings formed around a glowing gemstone made of an energy-based substance called ether, and Bearers, organic beings whose etheric bonds allow their Blades to manifest. Your journey takes place on the world of Arlest's Cloud Sea, a vast, nearly-empty ocean of fog, sparsely populated by living landmasses known as Titans. Throughout your adventures, your party, composed of teams of Blades and Bearers, will need to take advantage of your unique abilities to tackle whatever challenges lie in your path. To play this game, you will need 3-6 players, each with ideally at least 12 six-sided dice, and one person to be the Architect.

The Architect

The world of Arlest may already be defined in many ways, but the **Architect**, or game master, is the person who will flesh it out for this adventure. They will define the setting, create the people who populate it, decide on the difficulty of various tasks, and react to the decisions that the players make. Keep in mind, however, that the Architect is not here merely to tell a story to the players. It is the responsibility of the players and the Architect to shape that story together, through both the actions of the players and the responses of the Architect.

Teams

The party, the full group of all players, is composed of **Teams**. Teams are made up of one Bearer and one or two Blades. Although all relationships are extremely important in this game, the bonds between members of the same team are front and center. Everything from your battle tactics to the ways you interact with non-player characters will revolve around them. When starting a game, the first thing you will do is choose your teammate(s). It is recommended that you form pairs of two, one Blade to one Bearer, unless you have an odd number of players. As a note, if you are a Blade, the term **Partner** refers only to your Bearer, but if you are a Bearer, the term refers to all of your Blades.

*Terminology tip: This book uses a number of words with specific meanings for the game's mechanics. The first time one of these words is used, it will be **Capitalized, In Bold**. For easy reference, all of these mechanics terms are defined again in the glossary in [chapter 10](#)!*

Blades

Ether is an intangible force that permeates through all living beings, but Blades are beings composed entirely of ether. As such, they need to bond with a Bearer in order to manifest, otherwise laying dormant in their core. A bond between Bearer and Blade – and therefore, too, the Blade itself – grows more powerful the closer the two are, but it remains present across any distance. This bond is only broken on the death of the Bearer, causing the Blade to retreat to their core. Without ether to sustain themselves, the Blade loses almost everything born from that bond, including all of their memories.

Blades have superhuman abilities and are able to command their elemental aspect, a reflection of their innate etheric constitution's alignment. As a result, the ways Blades move and act, especially in combat, are vastly different from those they bond with. The strength drawn by the Blade, however, is not a one-way street. Bearers, too, can become quite powerful through these bonds.

Bearers

In order to forge a Blade, a being must have the potential to do so. That potential, by itself, grants no special powers and is completely undetectable before one bonds with a Blade. In fact, the only reliable test for potential is attempting to bond with a core. However, bonding with a Blade is hardly trivial. Cores are extremely rare on most Titans, and those with potential are even rarer. More importantly, failing to forge a Blade has a devastating physical effect on the would-be Bearer, sometimes even killing them.

Blades may use Bearers as a source of ether to keep them manifested, but that doesn't make them parasites. In fact, this relationship is symbiotic, and Bearers, even without the aid of their Blades, are much more powerful than the average being. As a manifestation of their bond, Bearers can summon an elemental etheric weapon as strong as the weapons Blades use.

The true power of both Bearers and Blades is not in their individual abilities, however. The bond between Blades and Bearers, both literal and metaphorical, is their greatest strength. Their tactical coordination, their trust in the heat of battle, and, perhaps most importantly, their emotional ties are what can really give them a leg up over even a minor Titan.

The Adventure

Maybe your party is full of freshly-forged Blades and brand-new Bearers, or maybe you're all grizzled veterans who've already seen a lifetime of action, but the most exciting journey of your lives is about to begin. This book will teach you how to make your characters, navigate the world of Arlest, and fight as a team. Read on, and show the Cloud Sea the power of your bonds!

Chapter 2: Beating the Odds

Some dismiss luck, declaring it for fools who waste their time playing cards and dice, but what is luck but stacking the deck in your favor? The world is random and chaotic, and chance permeates everything. The most skilled are those who understand how they're one dose of bad luck away from falling to a novice. After all, what is skill but playing to the odds?

While *Blades of Ether* is a narrative experience, letting players together craft their story of bonds and bravery across the Sea of Clouds, it is more than just a collaborative work of fiction. It is a game, and sometimes the game steps in to tell its own story. The Architect and players drive the story, but their intentions are not guaranteed to come to fruition exactly as they'd expect. When the outcome of an action is uncertain — perhaps a task is highly difficult, time-sensitive, competitive, subject to distraction, or otherwise likely to go awry — the game steps in, challenging characters to use the skills and traits they've earned on their adventures to back up their plans, and creating surprising and exciting outcomes to propel the story in new directions.

Rolling the Dice

Like in many tabletop games, uncertain outcomes are decided by rolling dice. When failure is a possibility, players will roll a number of six-sided dice, called their **Dice Pool**, to determine how they perform. Once the dice fall, each 5 or 6 shown represents a **Success**. Every roll has a **Check**, representing the difficulty of the challenge. If the total number of successes rolled is greater than the challenge's check, then the action in question succeeds. If it does not, it fails. The difference between the amount of successes rolled and the check is referred to as the roll's **Net Successes**.

Success and failure, however, are not mutually exclusive. When an action rolls one success greater than the check, it is a **Near Hit**. The action succeeds, but the Architect will introduce a narrative complication or unexpected consequence. Likewise, zero net successes, or meeting the check, is a **Near Miss**, and while the action fails, the Architect will offer a surprising benefit or unexpected change.

A roll's check is determined by the Architect and is not visible to players. Most tasks will have a check of 0, meaning they simply require at least one success. Some actions, however, might see players roll against other players, or rarely even against a dice pool made by the Architect. In the case of an "opposed" check like this, whoever rolls more successes sees things through as they intended. Ties result in near misses for both parties.

*Tutelage tip: Throughout this book, there will be narrative examples of a hypothetical *Blades of Ether* campaign. The Architect of this game is *Tori*, and the players are *Ren* and *Mia*, with their Bearer and Blade pair *Pyre* and *Doma*, and *Morgan* and *Zeke*, with their team of *Bridget* and *Pandora*. Pay attention to their adventures and you'll be prepared to undertake your own!*

Certain properties of a character or action will add or remove dice from one's dice pool. This is notated as an added or subtracted number such as +1 or -2. Note that this number changes the *quantity of dice in the dice pool*, not the number of successes on that roll. The rare effects that change a roll's count of successes will note explicitly that they do this. Should your dice pool drop below 1, roll one die regardless. However, failure will not only impact you, but another player as well.

"Since we have some downtime, I'd like to make a salvaging run," says Ren, who plays the Bearer Pyre.

Tori, the Architect, nods. "Alright. Pyre has a field skill in salvaging, right? Take +2."

Ren grabs two extra dice for their dice pool and rolls. The result is 3 2 4 4 6 2.

"... 4, 4, oh, a 6! That's one success!" Says Ren.

"That's a near hit," says Tori, "so here's what happens: you're down for a few hours with no real luck, but just when your air's starting to get low, you dig up a strange golden trinket! You rush it back up. You know salvage, so this doesn't seem to be worth much, but it's not nothing. However, and here's that near hit, in your hurry you pick up a stowaway crustacean. What do you do, Pyre?"

Purpose in Pips

Arlest is a fast, dynamic place, filled with fearsome creatures, inhuman prowess, and ancient wonders, and playing should be action-packed to the last. The dice system is designed with gameplay speed in mind, and rolling dice is meant to move the narrative forward with unexpected outcomes, not halt it. Therefore, as a rule, one uncertain action or plan is resolved by one roll. There are no repeating tests for endurance tasks or rolls to assist other players. Any complicating circumstances should be represented by the difficulty of the check. Dice pool bonuses for assistance between party members are solely dictated by characters' **Affinities**, as described on [page 10](#).

There is no need to roll if nothing is at stake. If an action has no possibility of failure, or if failure doesn't change the situation, move things along, or make the story more interesting, then you do not need to roll for it. Only when there's potential for interesting success *and* interesting failure are rolls performed. This may sound limiting, but it serves to keep the story moving as smoothly as possible, since wasting time on rolling just to have a result that doesn't really matter isn't particularly fun for anyone.

"Victory" or "failure" is not the end, though, and every roll is an opportunity to change the world, the story within it, and the characters that traverse it. Even without a near hit or near miss, a roll tells a story in more words than one. The total number of net successes a roll earns will have an effect on the outcome just as much as that critical first hit. Where one net success to spend a day exploring the Cloud Sea's mysterious depths might bring up a handful of rusty trinkets and bolts, three

successes would salvage a valuable item, and five brings up something so rare and unique as to shower the party in enough gold to keep them fed and famous for a year.

Likewise, the severity of failure matters: merely meeting the check on one's attempt to efficiently and safely travel the long, dangerous path across a Titan could bring you into town weary and short on supplies, while missing the check by a large number might mean you've come too close to the home of a highly territorial beast.

Above all else, let the narrative and the will of the characters guide the mechanics, not the other way around. Let characters fail, make suboptimal decisions, and get up, wipe the dirt off their faces, and try again, consequences be damned! The Cloud Sea is wider and wiser than anyone living in it, and it will challenge even its most gallant heroes in ways they cannot prepare for. Embrace difficulty, enjoy failure, and rise to every unexpected battle born of your choices. There is no other way, after all, to grow.

Forming a Dice Pool

When a player declares an action, the number of dice in their dice pool is determined by their value in the most relevant **Attribute**, one of a player's twelve skills or strengths, plus bonuses awarded by any other character properties that grant a dice pool modifier. Attributes will be discussed in greater detail in the next chapter, but for now it will suffice to say that each attribute represents how or why an action is performed more than the action itself. Examples of attributes include might, empathy, and improvisation.

The attribute you roll is not determined by the action itself, however, but by the narrative. When you declare an action, describe what you are doing and how and why you're doing it. **Do not declare what attribute you are rolling.** Once you've described how and why you are acting, the Architect will decide which attribute forms your dice pool. When you try to stay on your feet while warding an enemy's blow, are you attempting to hold your ground with every ounce of strength you have, acting carefully based on knowledge of how this foe tends to strike, or standing tall to protect your friends to the last? When you plead with the local business owner to get the artifact you need, are you making an impassioned speech, appealing to their business sensibilities, or perhaps invoking the greater good?

Any attribute can be used for any action, as long as you are able to describe why. While the Architect reserves the right to veto an action description if it does not make sense, you as the acting player have the power to defend your choices. However, certain methods and their respective attributes may prove to be disadvantageous at times. If you are fighting an opponent who is significantly larger and stronger than you, it's going to be hard to beat them in a test of might, but if every strike is infused with your willpower, then you can overcome them. Similarly, identifying a lie with calculation or knowledge will work well, attunement may incur some difficulty, and, unless circumstances are particularly exceptional, swiftness may not be able to succeed at all. To this end, the Architect is able to increase the

difficulty of a roll accordingly, assigning dice pool penalties or even declaring an automatic failure where appropriate.

"I want to investigate the area," Morgan, who plays the Bearer Bridget, says, "look for any clues."

"Alright," Tori responds. That's not enough information to assign an attribute, so she presses for details. "How do you go about it, Bridget?"

Morgan thinks for a moment. "Bridget isn't particularly knowledgeable about investigation, so I'm just trying to be thorough, look for the smallest details."

"That sounds like willpower to me."

"Can I do calculation?" Morgan asks. "Bridget's got the whole story in mind, and she's trying to put details to dust."

"Alright, calculation works. No modifier. Good luck!"

*"My calculation is 6, so... Roll!" Morgan tosses the dice, but they come up short: 4 2 2
3 1 2.*

"No luck, eh?" Tori says. "The check on this was 2, so the odds weren't exactly in your favor. You take your time, looking for something, anything to tie up the story, but your focus on those little details distracts you, and before you realize what's happening, you knock over a loose plank of wood, which falls into a few others, and the whole pile collapses and kicks up a bunch of dust and junk... And after that, you're pretty sure you're not gonna find anything else of note here."

Chapter 3: The Players

The powers Bearers and Blades share are more than the sum of their parts, but only by so much. What can be achieved together is only so grand as the skills and grit each partner brings to the table.

The adventures Bearers and their Blades undertake are trying, and not just in the way the word “Blade” brings to mind. This chapter presents the foundation that every Titan-traveller needs: firm beliefs, skills of all sorts, and trust in one’s companions.

Attributes and Ideas

Attributes are a character’s strengths and weaknesses, the parts of someone that they hold in their heart which come to the surface in times of action. Sorted within four **Ideas**, the values that attributes invoke, the twelve attributes represent how adept characters are at acting in certain ways. Every dice roll a character makes is based on an attribute, and the sum of the attributes in an idea give strength to a player character’s most powerful strikes in battle. The ideas and their attributes are:

Bravery: Drawing your sword in the face of danger, facing your fears, and putting your life on the line for someone else’s. These attributes let you face the insurmountable, the indomitable, and the unknowable with confidence and grace.

Might: Raw force applied, held, or resisted. Use this to bash down a door, call forth a Titan-sized fireball to crush your enemies, or carry your friends. Their burdens would be carried by willpower, though.

Willpower: Resolve, grit, and emotional strength. The attribute for casting complex arts or standing strong against the weight of the world.

Calculation: Sheer mental prowess. The ability to process the odds, think ahead, or comprehend a complex plan. You’d likely use improvisation to think on your feet, however.

Truth: What you know makes you who you are. Everything you’ve learned, everything you’ve practiced, and every instinct you’ve built up gives you strength. Justice is theory; truth simply is.

Gut: Following your instincts, listening to your heart, and acting on intuition. Where knowledge and experience fail you, always trust your gut.

Experience: The culmination of years of doing. Muscle memory and honed skill. Practice makes perfect!

Knowledge: Things you’ve read in books, were taught in school, or researched for yourself. This is for solving riddles and navigating libraries. You could use this to recall the flaw in a helmet’s design, but calculation could give you that in the heat of battle.

Compassion: Nothing worth doing benefits no one. Let kindness draw your sword, and let kindness, too, sheathe it. Be good to yourself, to others, and to the land, as without them you have nothing. Through these attributes, show what is truly worth fighting for.

Stamina: Knowing and honing your body keeps it sturdy. It doesn't matter if it's extreme weather, a blast of ether, or one more round of drinks, a high stamina will keep you standing.

Empathy: An intrinsic knowledge of what those around you, whether human or beast, are feeling. You could use this to comfort an ally, find common ground, or get in an opponent's head.

Attunement: The ground you stand on is a living creature, and the air you breathe is filled with power. Understanding the land and the ether it breathes allows you to learn from the world around you. Of course, when it comes to specifics, this is no substitute for knowledge or experience.

Justice: What is right and what is wrong. In a way, Justice is both the beginning and end of every other idea. It is only with a deep, assured sense of justice that one can act without thinking and still achieve the goals they truly believe in.

Swiftness: The ability to move quickly and with precision. Use this to close a gap, pick a lock, or outmaneuver an attack. You could use this to repair a watch, but knowledge or experience might be better.

Improvisation: Thinking on your feet, making split-second decisions, and acting when an opening presents itself. Improvisation is thinking fast; gut isn't thinking at all.

Passion: Move a crowd to laugh or cry, express your emotions, fight because you know it's right, or act with sheer excitement. It doesn't matter how long it takes or how many blisters it will give you when you love doing it.

The "value" of an idea is the sum of the three attributes that make it up. All attributes start with a value of 1 and can be raised all the way to 12 over the course of a character's journey in Arlest.

Combat Basics

In combat, characters have three forms of attack: **Basic Attacks**, **Arts**, and **Special Attacks**. Basic attacks can be performed at any time and have relatively little customization. Each combatant has three unique arts, which can only be used every few turns and can be customized with additional damage and special effects. Special attacks can only be performed with **Special Dice** accumulated by dealing damage over the course of battle, and can be combined in series with higher level specials to deal devastating damage. Combat rolls are detailed on [page 21](#).

Traits

Characters have four **Traits**, two of which are derived from their attributes. These additional values are important in combat, and their mechanics are detailed in the next chapter, but for now it will suffice to explain how they are calculated:

Basic Attack Range: The range of a character's basic attack starts as 1. Note that arts have their own ranges separate from one's basic attack's range.

Health Points (HP): the amount of damage a character can take in battle. A character's starting maximum HP is their willpower + stamina + 4. One's current HP can never go above its maximum; any HP restoration beyond this point is lost.

Initiative: a character's preparedness to fight, or the dice pool players roll before starting combat to determine the turn order. It is the greater of improvisation + gut or calculation + experience.

Movement: how quickly a character can move. This is not derived from a character's attributes, and will be discussed in the combat chapter. Movement has different uses for different characters, and as such, Bearers start with a movement of 3, while Blades start with a movement of 1.

Elemental Affinity

Blades are made of ether. They are fundamentally connected with the world's life force in a way no material being can be, and can tap into and manipulate it. Once bonded with a Blade, Bearers can tap into their partner's etheric reservoir, granting them this power as well. Ether can be divided into eight elements, and a Bearer or Blade's **Elemental Affinities** represent which facets they are most attuned to. This alignment determines the ways in which they can use the ether around them, including manifesting and controlling the element they are attuned to and invoking special combat effects. Each player character has at least one elemental affinity.

The eight elements are divided into four opposing pairs which are aligned with an idea. In addition to the unique combat effects that each element grants, these idea pairs have shared effects, and an element's idea alignment determines which special effects are available during the idea-based special attacks mentioned earlier. One's choice of elemental affinities represents their values, natural attunement, and, for Bearers, the nature of one's relationship with their partner. Fire and water are aligned with bravery, wind and ice with truth, earth and electricity with compassion, and light and dark with justice.

Bonds and Affinity

When a Bearer and a Blade come together, they form a bond unlike any other, manifest in ether and stronger than steel, lifelong and unflinching. This bond, however, is not the only one in a character's life, and every relationship they have empowers them. The **Bonds** between player characters are everything. They drive

the story forward, allow the characters to grow, and present the greatest challenges characters will have to overcome.

At the start of the game, you will define your character's bond with every other character in the party. Engaging with and changing the nature of your bonds is core to gameplay, and is how you'll receive **Bond Points (BP)** to grow your character (for more about bond points, see [page 37](#)). At the end of each session, the Architect will grant BP for playing to your bonds, as well as allow you to change them if your relationship has grown. Bonds are also a narrative framework, giving you and your fellow players the tools to create fun and meaningful interactions between characters. A bond consists of four components:

Name: a short description of your relationship with the character in question. You might be allies, friends, lovers, or anything else. Your bond is how you feel about them, and does not need to be mutual in any way. You can really like someone who absolutely hates your guts, or see someone as your mentor when they see you as a rival.

Benefit: an aspect of your relationship that makes you both stronger than you could be alone. Your rival can spur you to improve just to best them, your romantic relationship gives you someone to fall back on in times of trouble, and your admiration for your hero inspires you to greater heights. Of course, not every bond has an upside. Sometimes the existence of your enemy is nothing but a scar that hasn't healed.

Drawback: just as they have an advantage, bonds always come with a consequence, representing the problems or difficulties that the relationship brings you. Your rivalry can hinder your ability to work together, your romantic relationship can make disagreements more painful than they otherwise would be, and your admiration for your hero can bring you to compare yourself to them negatively.

Affinity: a number from -2 to +2 representing your current closeness to the person the bond is with. A positive number means that you're closer than normal, and a negative number means that your relationship is currently rocky, but all within your current bond. An arch-rivalry with an affinity of 2 is still far from the closeness a romance at -2 possesses. Even if a pair of bonds are different, their affinity level is shared.

More mechanical than the three narrative-driven parts of a bond, **Affinity** is increased and decreased at the Architect's discretion as you grow closer or fight between yourselves. The value is shared between both characters involved, so if it is -1 for you, it is -1 for them as well. Any check you make that involves a player character's help takes your shared affinity as a dice pool modifier. Similarly, if you have negative affinity with an ally, the Architect may state that your bond is interfering in your action, and your affinity becomes a negative modifier to that roll. Thus, as affinities rise and fall, so too do the difficulties of your actions.

Reconciliation Bursts

Bonds at high affinity will naturally fall off as their new state becomes a new norm, and while the same is true of negative affinities, there is another, more spectacular way out of a mired relationship. **Reconciliation Bursts** allow characters to bring a dramatic end to their destitute bond, “spending” their negative affinity in a moment of character growth to best a situation that forces them to set their differences aside. A pair of players with negative affinity can choose to use a reconciliation burst at any time by explaining how the situation at hand spurs their characters to grow past their turmoil and resetting their affinity to 0. Reconciliation bursts have different effects depending on whether the players are in combat and how low their affinity is:

Outside of combat, you set aside your differences to tackle a challenge. From -1, you walk in each others’ shoes, and each contribute an attribute to the dice pool one of you uses to overcome a check. From -2, you come to understand each others’ views, and the dice pool is the sum of each of your values in the Attributes you each use.

During combat, you come together to deal a massive blow to the enemy. From -1, you set your differences aside for the sake of an idea, allowing a level 1 special attack to be performed without cost by the player with the higher total value in that idea on their turn. From -2, you realize your differences make you stronger, and together perform a level 3 special attack without cost, each using an idea of your choice. These special attacks do not affect the current special attack combination (special attack mechanics are detailed on [page 27](#)).

Example Bonds

Best Friend: You have shared interests and opinions that encourage and embolden you, but it can be especially difficult to face disagreement or rejection from one so alike you.

Coworker: You know how to operate with perfect effectiveness and efficiency together, but it’s just business. The obligation you share seems to block you from getting closer.

I Hate Their Guts: In their own, obnoxious way, they push you to rise above them, though you’d never tell them this, and that doesn’t stop them from pissing you off.

Leader: You trust their plans and work at your best with them telling you what to do next. Unfortunately, they have a pesky habit of pinning their failures on you.

Lover: Love brings all the joy in the world, and you know they would stop at nothing to aid you. The intimacy you share, however, makes it all the more painful when things go wrong or they fail to live up to your enamored expectations.

My Mentee: You receive guidance from your teacher, and go to them when you're not sure what to do next. However, they often disregard your opinion when you disagree.

My Mentor: Your student will listen to you and trust what you have to say, but too often they expect answers from you that you could not possibly have.

My Guardian: You know, should you step into harm's way, they will be there to save you. To you, though, their dedication is little more than a frustrating obsession and a limit on your freedom, and it often pushes you into dangers you otherwise would have avoided.

My Ward: You'll stop at nothing to keep them safe and watch them thrive. However, your single-minded focus can blind you to more important things, including the situation at hand and even their happiness.

Owe Them a Debt: Without them, you would not be here, which is a benefit well worth remembering. Of course, the duty you feel to their cause can present all sorts of problems.

Rival: Nothing stokes the fire within you quite like rising to beat their challenge. When you butt heads, though, it can cause far more trouble than they're worth.

Uneasy Ally: They draw your curiosity, and you know the potential they bring could be beyond even your wildest expectations. Deep down, though, you wonder if you can truly trust them.

Unrequited Love: Oh, how you adore them, how their presence can make even the greatest tragedy seem alright. How your heart sinks when you remember they don't feel the same...

Play Tips: Roleplaying Bonds

Bonds and affinity are core mechanics designed to guide interactions with character relationships and personality, and as such should inform and be informed by your roleplay. Bonds and affinity are a combination of descriptive and prescriptive. No description can perfectly define a relationship, and people's connections grow and change over time, but keeping that status in mind and letting it inform your relationship can give more flavor to your interactions and relationship than it otherwise would. Sometimes, a move will tell you to change your affinity level, and the way you play should change in kind. Just follow the fiction and play your character honestly, allowing the mechanics to impact the game when they are relevant. Of course, you get BP for changing your relationships and growing closer, so there's always good reason to play!

In stories about character relationships, you will often unfold unhealthy or difficult bonds. Even with characters who are thick as thieves, it can be difficult; playing two best friends alongside someone you are not very well acquainted with could

potentially be awkward. As well, character and self can bleed together, and not always in a good way. As such, It's always important to communicate with your fellow players and use your safety tools when appropriate. Make sure that your partner understands your character's relationship with theirs and that they are both comfortable and interested in that narrative. Your characters don't have to know everything, but the players should. Indeed, there's a lot of fun in getting into difficult or one-sided relationships, setting up moments of dramatic irony, or subtly pushing things to get your characters' relationships to change. You're all authors in the story you're telling, so be sure all your above-table teammates are all on the same page.

Finally, *Blades of Ether* as a game is very interested in character relationships and bonds, and our mechanics are made to reflect the way that relationships work inside media with the tone we're attempting to capture. However, this is not reflective of every relationship or every way two people can connect. Indeed, it *shouldn't* be. So while the mechanics are made to create the specific tone that this game aims for, if your relationships are ever limited by them or pushed into an unhealthy place because of them, please do not feel obligated to continue down that road. Comfort, narrative, and being honest to the world and characters is more important than playing the game as writ. If you do need to rework things in such a way, please, contact the authors, we'd be interested to know what went wrong and if we need to rework the game to make it work better.

Combats, Sessions, and Arcs

Gameplay is divided along several units of time. Of course, events in Arlest may take minutes, hours, days, or longer, but for a player, the game is divided into **Combats, Sessions, and Arcs**. Each of these units of time have different ramifications for gameplay. During combat, unique mechanical rules are introduced in place of the general narrative-driven system. Each time characters begin and end use of these special rules is one combat. Players sit down for one session of gameplay at a time, typically two to three hours, and often featuring one combat, though combats can stretch across multiple sessions. Sessions are grouped into arcs, over the course of which the characters accomplish a major goal, affect notable change in Arlest, or otherwise advance the plot meaningfully. Arcs are typically three to six sessions long and end at the Architect's discretion.

Many abilities characters can have specify that they are usable once per combat, once per session, or once per arc. In addition to those acquired via character upgrades or other unique means, there are three universal once-per-arc abilities that every player character has access to:

I'm Really Feeling It: Once per arc, before rolling initiative, you may declare yourself exceptionally motivated for combat. Describe why, then add the most relevant attribute to your initiative dice pool (which can be a second instance of any of the four attributes used in base initiative calculation), and start combat with a free special die showing a six.

It's Reyn Time: Once per arc, you may guarantee your success on a roll.

The Heronop Special: Once per arc, you may turn a failed roll into a near miss, allowing the Architect to introduce a narrative complication that results from your efforts.

Note that these abilities are meant to enable characters to advance the plot and shine in moments important to them and the narrative, not game the system for impossible outcomes. The Architect has the final say on the use of these abilities, including on the attribute chosen for I'm Really Feeling It, in service to an interesting and exciting game.

Weapons

After Blades' etheric and often strange forms, the next most iconic thing about Bearers and Blades are perhaps their weapons. These etheric arms manifest from the energy flowing between partners and act as an output for a Blade's power, allowing ether to enhance arts and abilities on the field of battle. As literal representations of the nature of one's identity and bond, no two ether weapons are alike. These unforgettably unique, eclectic, and often dual-natured weapons — whip-swords, drill-hammers, ether-blades, knuckle-claws, bow-shields, gun-lances — are an extension and reflection of those who will them forth and the ties they share.

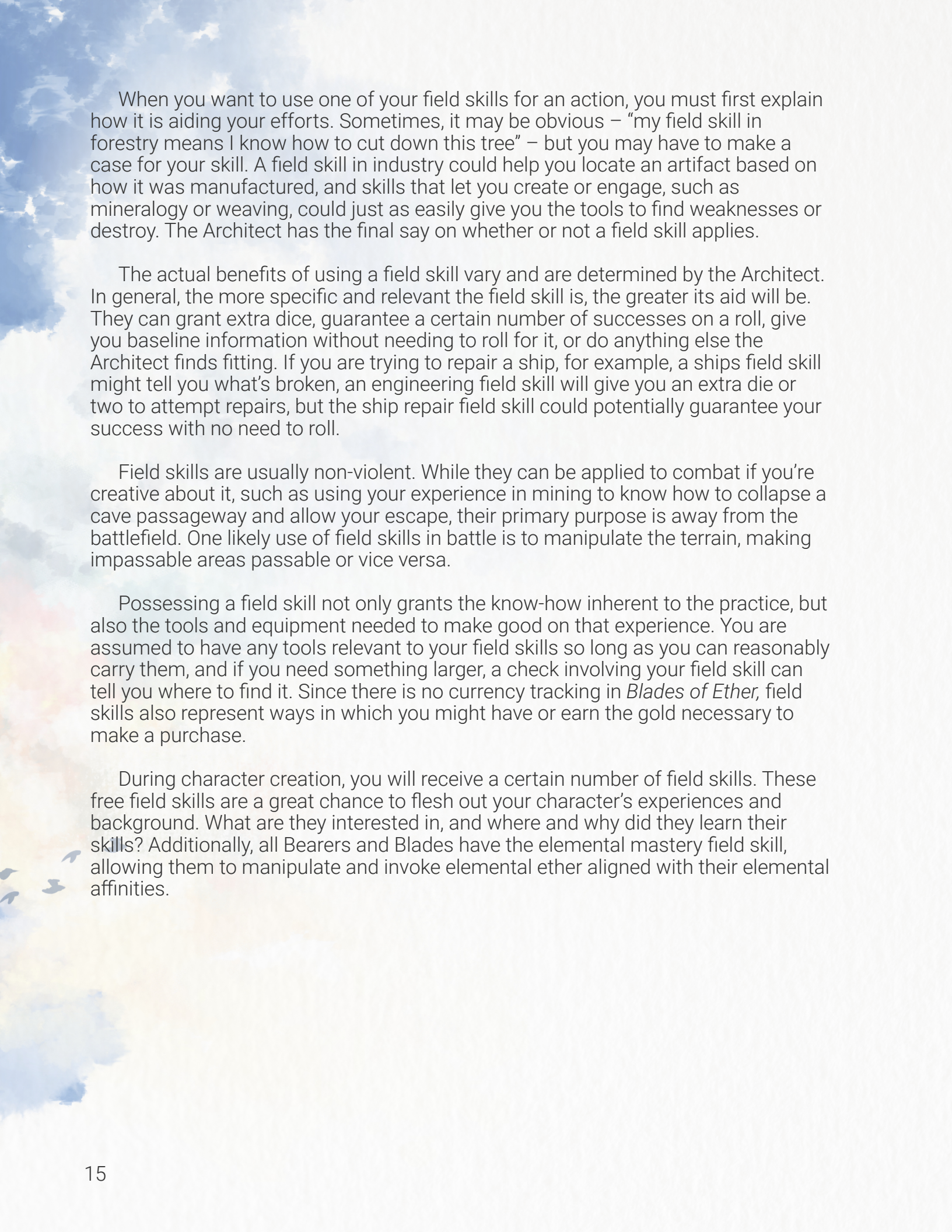
In *Blades of Ether*, a weapon is a weapon, and its unique properties are represented by arts tags and fighting style rather than actual statistics or mechanics. Treat your weapon as an extension of what makes your character and bond unique, not a tool, number, or optimization.

Talents and Field Skills

Over the course of an adventure, characters will pick up unique abilities, prowesses, and techniques. These are **Talents**, one-of-a-kind powers that can greatly boost and enhance a character's skills with unique rules and effects. Talents are divided into several categories: general talents give general abilities, while combat talents enhance a character's combat arsenal; universal talents can be taken by anyone, but Bearers and Blades each have access to unique talents derived from their natures and experiences; **Pair Talents** have special partnership effects on being acquired by a Bearer and Blade pair; and finally, **Archetype Talents** are special talents that dramatically alter a character's nature and grant access to further specialized talents relevant to that archetype.

The complete list of talents is in [chapter 6](#).

Every character has things they excel at outside of the bounds of their adventure. **Field Skills** are these vocations, skillsets, fields of expertise, and hobbies, and they will come in handy all over Arlest. For Bearers, field skills typically represent interests and past time investments. Blades' field skills are a mix of natural affinities, senses built up during previous bonds, and, if a bond lasts long enough, new personal undertakings between adventures.



When you want to use one of your field skills for an action, you must first explain how it is aiding your efforts. Sometimes, it may be obvious – “my field skill in forestry means I know how to cut down this tree” – but you may have to make a case for your skill. A field skill in industry could help you locate an artifact based on how it was manufactured, and skills that let you create or engage, such as mineralogy or weaving, could just as easily give you the tools to find weaknesses or destroy. The Architect has the final say on whether or not a field skill applies.

The actual benefits of using a field skill vary and are determined by the Architect. In general, the more specific and relevant the field skill is, the greater its aid will be. They can grant extra dice, guarantee a certain number of successes on a roll, give you baseline information without needing to roll for it, or do anything else the Architect finds fitting. If you are trying to repair a ship, for example, a ship's field skill might tell you what's broken, an engineering field skill will give you an extra die or two to attempt repairs, but the ship repair field skill could potentially guarantee your success with no need to roll.

Field skills are usually non-violent. While they can be applied to combat if you're creative about it, such as using your experience in mining to know how to collapse a cave passageway and allow your escape, their primary purpose is away from the battlefield. One likely use of field skills in battle is to manipulate the terrain, making impassable areas passable or vice versa.

Possessing a field skill not only grants the know-how inherent to the practice, but also the tools and equipment needed to make good on that experience. You are assumed to have any tools relevant to your field skills so long as you can reasonably carry them, and if you need something larger, a check involving your field skill can tell you where to find it. Since there is no currency tracking in *Blades of Ether*, field skills also represent ways in which you might have or earn the gold necessary to make a purchase.

During character creation, you will receive a certain number of field skills. These free field skills are a great chance to flesh out your character's experiences and background. What are they interested in, and where and why did they learn their skills? Additionally, all Bearers and Blades have the elemental mastery field skill, allowing them to manipulate and invoke elemental ether aligned with their elemental affinities.

Example Field Skills

Animal Handling: an understanding of animal behavior, taming, and care.

Animalspeak: the ability to speak to animals.

Birdbrain: the ability to miraculously forget anything, no matter how important.

Blue-Bellied Bird Squid: you have a profoundly deep understanding of this particular type of flying squid that lives in the seas near your Titan in the winter.

Charisma: you've got a lot of energy and charisma, and people tend to enjoy being around you.

Cooking: skill with all forms of cooking and food preparation.

"Cooking": "skill" with "all" forms of "cooking" and "food" preparation.

Elemental Mastery: the ability to manipulate an element with a great degree of control and precision.

Eye for Weapons: you know a ton about weapons and can spout off facts about any given blade. Wielding them is a different matter entirely, though.

Forestry: knowledge of trees, forests, and lumber.

Mapmaking: you make beautifully rendered maps of the environment around you.

Medicine: knowledge of bodily functions, curative herbs, and medicinal treatments.

Medicine(?): knowledge of ethically dubious tinctures, questionable potions, and experimental theories you haven't been able to test.

Painting: the ability to put brush to canvas and create works of visual art.

Sea of Clouds: the tides, creatures, and ebb and flow of the sea of clouds.

Chapter 4: Combat

Nothing tests the unity of a Blade and their Bearer like crossing swords with another team.

When disagreements cannot be solved with word or wile, weapons take over. If there is little hope of resolving a situation amicably or with one creative strike, you enter **Combat**, which has its own special rules detailed in this section. Before starting combat, set aside three dice for each player, as well as an additional set of three for each team, for tracking special combat resources. Combat also requires a grid of squares for characters to move on and attack across; this grid can be as large or small as the Architect's battle design calls for, and can have obstructed squares and walls between or through squares as appropriate for the environment. Each player needs two **Tokens**, sized appropriately to fit in one grid square: one to represent their place on the grid, and another for the turn order.

The Grid, Initiative, and Turns

In *Blades of Ether*, combat is played using tokens on a grid of squares. Each square represents one square meter (or a yard, if you like). To start combat, each player places a character token marking their current position, and the Architect places tokens representing non-player combatants. Only one combatant can be in any given square, and some squares may be occupied by objects or unmanageable terrain which combatants will have to move around entirely. Additionally, there may be dividers between squares that block passage without taking up a whole space.

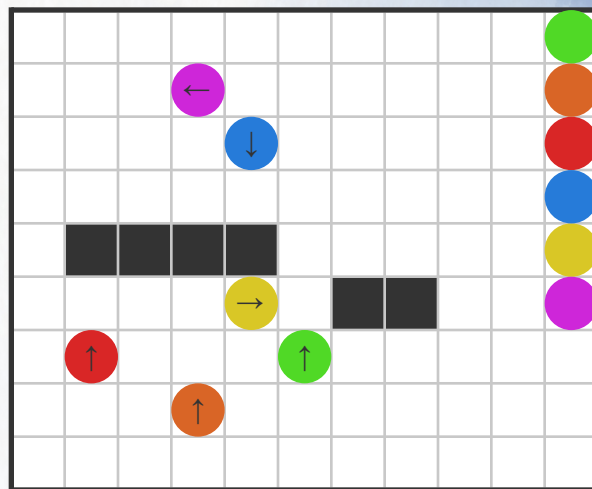
Combat is ordered by **Turns**. Once you are on the grid, roll **Initiative** to determine the turn order. Initiative, as detailed on [page 9](#), is a dice pool composed of the higher of improvisation + gut or calculation + experience. The highest roll result will go first, and the lowest last; in the event of a tie, the character with the higher initiative dice pool goes first.

The initiative values rolled by players are **Team Initiative Slots**, representing when members of a certain team can act. At the start of combat, team members can choose the order they act in, distributing themselves among their team slots however they'd like. On your turn, you may choose to swap this turn and your partner's next turn. Excepting the use of certain talents, you cannot perform a turn swap again until every team member has taken a turn. Bearers and Blades are at their best when they fight as one, so use your pool of turns to strike where it will hit hardest!

Turn order tip: The once-per-arc special ability I'm Really Feeling It (13) allows you to add an additional stat to your initiative dice pool. You must declare that you are using this ability before rolling your initiative.

Once you have rolled initiative and decided on your initial turn orders, use a second set of character tokens to list the order, ordering the first character at the top of the list and the last character at the bottom. After your turn, move your token from

the top to the bottom of the list. In combat, there are a number of actions that will change the turn order, moving combatants ahead or behind. Swap tokens in the initiative list as needed. Note that all turn order changes occur at **the end of the turn on which they are applied**, after moving the current turn player's token to the bottom of the turn order.



An example battle grid.

From a story perspective, turns represent both a small amount of time passing and a temporary spotlight in the scene's focus, not necessarily a strict count of seconds nor a free narrative construct. On your turn you'll do two things: move and perform an action. Your movement can be performed both before and after acting. In general, your action consists of one act you'll need to roll dice to perform, whether it be an attack or something else with an uncertain outcome. Small actions that do not require dice rolls such as drawing a weapon, calling out to a party member, or picking up an object from the ground do not consume your action, though the Architect may decide that enough of these "free" actions consumes a whole turn.

"Alright," says Tori, "that's the team order: Bridget and Pandora, two arachno, Pyre and Doma twice, an arachno, and then Bridget and Pandora. Who wants to go first?"

Morgan and Zeke look at each other, and Morgan speaks first. "I'd like to go first, if you don't mind. My Art 'Radiance' has an area of effect break, so we can try to get some topples in quickly."

Zeke agrees, and Ren and Mia settle on Pyre going first without much discussion. Everyone sets their turn order tokens in a line at the edge of the grid: Bridget, two NPC tokens, Pyre, Doma, an NPC token, and lastly Pandora. Combat starts and blows are traded, but after some few rounds, things aren't looking good for our hypothetical heroes. Pyre is all but surrounded by the remaining arachno, and Doma is in his third radius, unable to protect his Bearer. It's Bridget's turn, but she doesn't think she can do much to help her ally in need.

"Wait!" Zeke exclaims suddenly. "Morgan, swap turns with me! I've got an art that can move Pyre's turn forward enough to get her out!"

Sighs of relief echo across the table as Morgan nods. Pandora's art hits, and Zeke chooses to move Pyre forward by one in the turn order with the art's effect. Disaster has been averted!

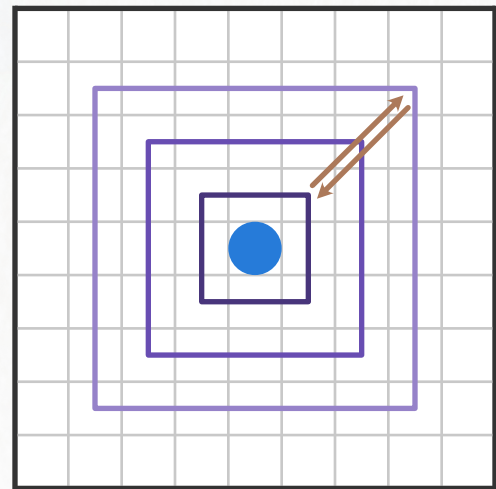
Movement and Facing

In order to attack the enemy, one must first meet them in the field of battle. On the grid, Bearers and Blades each have specific rules for how and how much they can move in a turn. Though these rules are fundamentally distinct, knowledge of both kinds of characters' abilities will be paramount to success in battle, so be sure to understand your partner's capabilities.

Movement on the grid is performed square-by-square. Moving one square means moving horizontally or vertically, not diagonally. Moving "one square" diagonally actually requires two squares of movement. Movement can occur before or after acting, and can be split between the two. On your turn, if you do not use a basic attack, art, special, or action that otherwise directly engages an enemy, you can move up to twice as far as normal while still performing that non-offensive action. If you need to get somewhere even faster, you'll have to use talents or find another way to turn the situation in your favor.

Bearers are limited to moving a certain number of grid squares per combat turn. By default, this limit is 3, or 6 when not attacking.

Blades, being fundamentally immaterial, etheric beings, are concerned less with the ground underfoot than their position relative to their Bearer. The **Blade Radius System** reflects this, and dictates a Blade's movement and strengths as they get closer to and farther from their partner. At any given time, a Blade is in a certain **Radius**, a square "circle" that centers on the Blade's Bearer. Radii start at 3x3, referred to as the *first* or *lowest* radius, and expand up to 7x7, the *third*, *highest* radius.



The three radii around a Bearer.

During their turn, a Blade is not bound to any particular square in their current radius. They can be anywhere and everywhere, moving freely about their Bearer's position. Where they are limited is movement between radii, only able to move up or down one radius per turn (two if they do not perform an attack action). When a Blade's turn ends, they must be placed in a grid square in their current radius, and will remain there until their next turn or until they are otherwise moved. Note that effects that prevent Blades from moving keep Blades in the square they were in when the effect was applied, unable to move about their current radius or change radii.

As Blades get farther away from their Bearers, they get weaker. Blades take -1 to all actions when in their third radius. They are severely disadvantaged outside of their maximum radius, and roll half the number of dice they normally would (rounded up if needed, rolling only four dice if they would normally roll seven, or two instead of three). They are locked to one grid square of movement per turn until they reenter one of their radii. Being in certain radii can have other situational advantages,

allowing a Blade to defend their Bearer or make advantageous attacks using certain art effects and talents detailed in other parts of the book.

Talent tip: The Bearer talents Quick Step and Fleet of Foot (47) increase a Bearer's movement to 4 and 5 respectively. The Blade talents Living Amalgam (49), Radius Master, Swift Slide, and Expeditionist (50) can give Blades additional, higher radii, more radius movements per turn, and reduce the penalty for being outside one's maximum radius!

Since Blade radii are centered on their Bearer, a Bearer moving changes a Blade's radius. When a Bearer moves in a way that would shift their Blade to a different radius, that Blade has a choice: stay in their current square and have their radius changed, or be moved to the nearest square in their shifted radius. The Blade is not given this choice if their Bearer is moved against their will, and are forced to stay in the square they were in, whatever radius that would put them in. Controlling enemy Bearer and Blade teams' proximities and radii is essential to success in combat, as the same advantages afforded to players are afforded to non-player combatants.

In addition to one's place on the grid, the direction a combatant faces is important information. Character tokens must offer some indication of which way the character is facing on the grid, and can be faced in any of the four cardinal directions.

There are two times when someone's facing will change: firstly, at the end of a combatant's turn, they can turn to face in any cardinal direction they'd like; secondly, when an attack occurs, the attacker turns to face the nearest cardinal to their target before striking, and the target then turns to face the nearest cardinal direction to the attacker's position after the attack resolves. If the attacker and target are at a perfect diagonal, the attacker chooses which of the two nearest cardinal directions they and their target will face. Choose your facing wisely, as certain attacks may have positional advantages and hit harder when performed facing a target's rear or sides.

After narrowly dodging the now-only arachno attack between her and freedom thanks to Pandora's aid, it's Pyre's turn. Ren picks up Pyre's token and quickly moves it 6 squares away from the spider horde surrounding her.

"I'm not attacking. My HP's low and I want to get to a safe distance," says Ren.

Tori nods. "Doma, this move puts you in your second radius around Ren. Do you want to stay there or move back out to third?"

"Definitely stay," Mia replies. "I don't think those arachno are going to be happy about Pyre moving, and now that I'm the closest one to them, I don't want that -1."

"Alright. Pyre, don't forget to face however you want at the end of your turn."

"Well," Ren says, "I don't want to get snuck up on." He turns Pyre's token to face the arachno.

Attacking and Defending

Once you've moved into position, it's time to strike. Attacking and defending isn't built on special rules or dice rolls, instead using the same narrative-first attribute dice pool that the rest of the system employs. Every attack has a **Range**, which is the distance in squares around you that your attack can hit. The base range of any attack against a single target is one square, meaning it can only be targeted in the four cardinal directions. A range of two, as with movement, is required to strike at a diagonal.

To attack a target, one must be able to see them. An attack is possible only if the attacker has a reasonable line of sight to their target. Some squares may be impassable but allow certain attacks at the Architect's discretion; a wooden fence, cobbled-together wall, or other partial cover may allow some weapons to strike even if they block combatants from moving through them. Note that numbered range only applies to the gridded battlefield; whether an attack can strike someone outside of the grid, and how difficult doing so is, is left to the Architect.

Though attacks have some unique mechanics, they are performed just the same as any other uncertain event: player characters will roll an attribute based on the narrative to attack or defend, checked against an opponent's defense or attack. Near hits and near misses still take effect, and any bonuses or setbacks from abilities or circumstances apply as normal. If the attack has any net successes over the defense, it succeeds, dealing **Damage** equal to the net successes. As with outside of combat, non-player characters use check values set by the Architect to keep gameplay fast-paced and exciting.

When attacking and defending, as with any other action, strive to be creative and honest to your character rather than simply playing to the attribute with the highest number value. If you're attacking an enemy with a sword, it may seem obvious that you would roll might, but that may not always be true depending on your character's fighting style. If you are attacking quickly, striking faster than the enemy can react, it would be better to roll swiftness. If you are striking a friend, desperately hoping that they will come back to your side, for them to be your friend again, then you could roll with empathy.

Basic Attacks

Basic attacks, the first of a combatant's attack options, are as simple as they seem. To use a basic attack, you'll name a target within your **Basic Attack Range** and roll as normal. Your net successes become the amount of damage you deal to the target. Basic attacks can be anything: a powerful swing, a flurry of blows, or even a clean punch or clever trick that doesn't employ your bond weapon. A player's basic attack range starts as 1, but can have its range extended by up to 5 using bond points. There is no cooldown or spendable resource associated with basic attacks.

"Okay, now it's actually arachno-number-two's turn since Pyre jumped ahead," Tori says, picking up the arachno's token. Tori moves it three spaces, putting it in a

square adjacent to Doma.

Mia smiles. "Oh no! A spider! Am I getting attacked?"

"Unfortunately, you are," Tori says. "The arachno hits you with a basic attack, lunging at you with its pincers. What do you do, Doma?"

"I just act on instinct, really. Quick dodge, it's just one spider!" says Mia.

"Sounds like gut to me. I hope your confidence is warranted - roll it!"

Mia tosses five dice, Doma's gut value, but they come up short: 4 3 1 2 2.

"Not quite! That's a near hit, so you take one damage," says Tori, "but here's the upside: you're big, and that tiny arachno had to lunge hard, so now they're off-balance - broken."

Arts

Arts are your signature moves. Over the course of your journey, you'll improve, redesign, and customize your three arts to your liking using **Tags**, giving them new properties including extended range, areas of effect, positional advantages, special effects, and bonuses. An art's range is not affected by a character's basic attack range. In addition to battering the enemy, arts can heal and support the party. These beneficial abilities have their own targeting rules separate from the attack's range.

Each of your three arts has a **Cooldown**, which is the number of turns it takes for an art to be available to use again. By default, an art's cooldown is 6, though this can be reduced with the Cooldown -1 art tag. Certain elemental effects and talents can also decrease an art's cooldown speed temporarily. After you use an art, place a die with that art's cooldown facing up on that art on your character sheet. At the end of your turn, reduce the value of any of these **Cooldown Dice** you have by 1. If you end your turn with a 1 on a cooldown die, remove that die, and your art will therefore be available to use starting next turn. Arts become unavailable and trigger their cooldowns after use even if the art attack misses.

When you begin combat, one of your arts is ready, one has a cooldown die with two turns remaining, and one has a cooldown die with four turns remaining; you may choose which cooldowns apply to which arts each battle.

Talent tip: The talents Secondary Accelerator and Prime Position (44) reduce the starting arts cooldowns further. Additionally, the healing abilities of arts are limited. For more powerful recovery at greater cost, try the talents Healer, Elite Healer, and Master Healer (45).

Arts customization uses a tag system. You purchase tags for each of your three arts using bond points, improving them or giving them new properties. At the end of an arc, you can fully refund one tag, turning it back into BP for you to spend on new

art tags, attributes, field skills, or talents. At character creation, each art starts with a Potency +1 tag applied.

Each tag is in a **Category**, and each category has a base **Category Cost** in bond points. An art can only have one tag from a given category, with the exception of the *fundamentals* category. Certain tags can be improved by purchasing that tag multiple times per art. These tags have a maximum listed; if a tag does not indicate a maximum, it can only be applied to an art once. *Other* is a group for tags that are not categorized and have their own cost rules. Bond point costs will be detailed on [page 37](#), but the cost of adding a tag to an art goes up for each tag in that category already on that art, including both unique and improvable tags, so choosing tags carefully is an important part of building arts.

Art tags					
Fundamentals Category cost 3	Area of Effect Category cost 15	Reactions Cat. cost 5	Positionals Category cost 3	Elemental Effects Cat. cost 4, requires affinity	Other Cost varies
Potency +1 Max 5	Circle Attack Max 2	Break	Side Advantage Bearers only	Unique Elem. Effect Any element	Range +1 Base cost 2 Max 5
Healing Potion	Line Attack	Topple	Rear Advantage Bearers only	Invigorating Steam Fire or water	Precise Attack Cost 10
Cooldown -1 Max 2		Launch	Pincer Attack Blades only	Bitter Snowstorm Wind or ice	
		Stagger		Counter Spike Earth or electricity	
		Rush Max 2		Blinding Eclipse Light or dark	

Fundamentals (category cost 3): the most basic tags, giving you increased precision and damage, healing yourself or your allies, and reducing your art's cooldown. Each art starts with a Potency +1 applied. An art can have any number of tags from this category.

Potency +1 (max 5): increase the power and precision of this art, granting +1 to attacking with it.

Healing Potion: capture the etheric energy unleashed through this crossing of swords in a curative concoction, restoring HP equal to the net successes of your attack roll to yourself or any one party member of your choice. When used in an area of effect attack, the heal's chosen beneficiary gains HP equal to the highest net successes versus any one target in the affected area.

Cooldown -1 (max 2): reduce an art's cooldown, making it available for use one turn sooner per tag.

Area of Effect (category cost 15): target more foes, dealing damage in a circle or line. Note that area arts apply their damage and detrimental effects to every combatant in the targeted area except for the attacker, regardless of whether that target is an ally or enemy (the other tag Precise Attack allows for individual targeting). Players caught in area attacks roll to dodge individually. Area of effect arts have a base range of zero, not one, and can only be extended with the other tag Range +1.

Circle Attack (max 2): apply damage and detrimental effects to any number of targets in a 3x3 square area, centered up to a number of squares away from the attacker equal to the art's bonus range. Purchasing this tag again increases the attack area to 5x5.

Line Attack: apply damage to any number of targets in a straight, cardinal line extending 5 squares from the attacker, plus additional squares equal to the art's bonus range.

Reactions (category cost 5): these martial techniques let you sweep your enemies off their feet, push them away, slow them down, or give you extra movement. A target cannot be toppled or launched unless they are presently broken. Reaction effects only take place if the art attack succeeds.

Break: force your target onto unsteady footing, rendering them vulnerable to being toppled or launched. The broken status lasts until the applier's next turn, and is extended an additional whole turn cycles if another break is are applied.

Topple: knock a broken target over through their next turn, during which they cannot move or take an action. A toppled target can defend, but attacks automatically succeed with one net success (as a near hit) if they would have failed. Removes break on application, and cannot be extended. Any combatant can use their action to help a toppled combatant in an adjacent square to their feet, removing the toppled status.

Launch: force a broken target away, moving them a number of squares equal to the attack's net successes in the direction you are facing to attack (if you and your target are diagonally aligned, the launch direction is your choice of the two most appropriate cardinals). Removes break on hit. If an untraversable square is in the target's path, they are stopped in front of it and take collision damage equal to the number of remaining squares they would have traveled. If another combatant is in the target's path, the target continues along their path, and the other combatant takes damage equal to the number of remaining travel squares. The target is moved back by one in the turn order upon reaching the end of their path unless they are obstructed by terrain.

Stagger: stun your target, forcing them back by one in the turn order.

Rush (max 2): seize the momentum from your strike and displace, granting you one extra square of movement per tag after using this art.

Positionals (category cost 3): take advantage of an enemy's weak points, hitting them where it hurts most. Positional attacks on Bearers can have their positional bonus negated by their Blade if the Blade is in the same or closer radius as the attacker's position. Doing so automatically moves that Blade to the nearest square between their Bearer and the attacker, bringing them to a lower radius if appropriate, or the closest square adjacent to the attacker if the Blade and attacker are both in the Blade's lowest radius. Note that positional bonuses are checked before the target turns to face the attacker.

Side Advantage (Bearers only): when you strike an enemy from one of their cardinal sides with this art, gain +1.

Rear Advantage (Bearers only): when you strike an enemy from behind them with this art, gain +2.

Pincer Attack (Blades only): team up with your Bearer to box your target in. When your target is occupying a square in a radius lower than your current radius, gain +2. This bonus does not apply outside your maximum radius.

Elemental Effects (category cost 4): invoke the power of your elemental affinities, inflicting your enemies with damaging statuses or supporting your allies. The Unique Elemental Effect tag allows you to choose any one unique elemental effect for an element you have affinity for each time you use the art. Additionally, each idea and its corresponding element pair has a shared elemental effect; these themselves are tags and must be applied to arts individually. You can only use unique effects and shared effect tags from this category that you have the requisite elemental affinity for.

Any elemental effect that applies for a duration has a maximum duration of six of the named unit of time. It is recommended you use a die to keep track of effects applied to your character. If an effect is applied to a target who presently has that effect inflicted on them, the new duration and old duration are added together, but the same 6-unit maximum applies. Elemental effects, harmful or beneficial, only occur if the art attack succeeds.

Unique Elemental Effect: draw on the power of the ether around you, applying one effect of your choice corresponding to an element you have an affinity for:

Burning Blade (fire): deals 1 damage at the start of the target's turn for a number of their turns equal to the attack's net successes.

Arts Seal (water): on the target's next turn, they cannot use an art, and their arts cooldowns do not change.

Blustering Gale (wind): grants one party member +1 to all defense rolls for turns equal to the attack's net successes.

Freezing Force (ice): freezes the target in place until your next turn. If used on a Bearer, their Blade is stuck in their present radius. If used on a Blade, the Blade cannot move at all, including within their current radius, and any movement by their Bearer automatically changes the Blade's radius.

Cradling Earth (earth): for yourself or one ally of your choice, removes any active detrimental effects and blocks any new ones until your next turn.

Electrifying Burst (electricity): a surge of electric power either pushes the target back or yourself or an ally forward one place in the turn order. Note that the ally effect only ever applies to one combatant.

Blade of Light (light): grants the power of guiding light to one party member. This boon has differing effects for non-Blades and Blades: a non-Blade gains +2 range to all attacks for turns equal to the attack's net successes. A Blade given this effect can freely move to any square in any of their radii at any time without incurring any radius or out-of-radius penalties during their next turn, allowing both pincer attacks and positional protection for their Bearer.

Shadow Manipulation (dark): bewilders your enemies with shadows, preventing them from attacking anyone but yourself or an ally of your choice for turns equal to the attack's net successes.

Invigorating Steam (bravery, requires fire or water affinity): energizes yourself or an ally of your choice, making one art available one turn sooner. This can be applied to the next cooldown of an art that is ready or an active cooldown die.

Bitter Snowstorm (truth, requires wind or ice affinity): creates an area of violent weather around the target, reducing their movement (minimum 0) and attack ranges (minimum 1) by 1 for turns equal to the attack's net successes.

Counter Spike (compassion, requires earth or electric affinity): cloaks yourself in highly-charged ether, dealing one damage back to anyone who successfully attacks you for turns equal to the attack's net successes.

Blinding Eclipse (justice, requires light or dark affinity): obstructs the target's vision, forcing -1 on their attack and defense rolls until after your next turn.

Other tags (cost varies): these tags have their own base costs, unaffected by categorization rules or any other tags.

Range +1 (max 5, base cost 2): extends the range of an art by one per tag, whatever area of effect that art has.

Precise Attack (cost 10): fling fire fearlessly into the fray with this tag that allows area of effect arts to spare allies or any other targets of choice from the art's damage and detrimental effects.

Knowing Doma's turn is next, Mia is smirking. "It's funny you say that, Tori, because I just-so-happen to have a freshly off-cooldown topple art this turn!"

"Oho, retaliation time?" Tori replies. "Sure is nice of your Architect to set you up like this..."

Tori and Mia exchange a high-five, and then Tori moves Doma's token three squares to be on the arachno's side. "I hit it with my art, Gemini Round - Potency +1, Side Advantage, and Topple. Hard and fast. Not giving it a chance to get back up."

"Swiftness?" Tori asks.

Mia nods. "It's not Doma's best Attribute, but where's the fun in optimizing?"

Mia rolls five dice: three for Doma's swiftness, one from Side Advantage, and one from Potency +1. This time, luck is on Doma's side: 5 3 2 4 6!

"Yes!" Mia cheers. "That's two damage and one arachno down!"

Tori nods. "Yup! You come at that arachno well before it can react, so it's toppled until your next turn. Great hit!"

Tori turns the arachno's token to face Doma. Mia turns Doma's token to face the other two arachno in case they come for Doma.

Special Attacks

As battle flows, tension builds, and the scales of combatants' wills to succeed tip ever deeper in effort to come out on top. For player characters, this growing tension manifests in **Special Attacks**, which allow Bearers and Blades to come together to deliver massive blows and combine these grand strikes in sequence to reach ever higher levels of destruction.

To track battle tension, teams earn one **Special Point** on each turn that they deal damage with a basic attack or art. These points are tracked with **Special Dice**, a pool of up to three dice that stores up to 18 points. Upon receiving a special point, place a die showing a 1 on your team's special dice tracker. Five more points raises this die from 1 to 6, and one more lets you place a second die, and so on for a third die. A team can only have three special dice at a time, and any special points earned above 18 are lost.

A "full" special die showing a 6 can be spent to unleash a first level special attack. After this basic special is used, the battle tension rises, and the next special attack increases in both cost and power, costing two full special dice for a second-level attack and three dice for the third and final. Unleashing a third-level special attack resets the combination and allows a new chain to be started with a single-die, first-level special attack. Performing a successful special attack combination requires

coordination across every team in combat. However, there are special rules to enable different numbers of player teams in a group to succeed:

One-team party: special dice are not consumed until a level three combination special attack is used, allowing that team to perform a special combination on their own. The requisite number of full dice must still be present for a special of a given level to be performed, however.

Two-team party: special dice are consumed as normal. However, after one team performs a level two combination special, the other receives one full special die.

Three-team party or larger: use no special rules. Any special attack costs a number of full dice equal to that special attack's level, meaning the three or more teams must work together to reach a level three combination special.

Once a team has the requisite special dice, it's time to unleash a special attack. Special attacks are performed not by rolling a dice pool based on an attribute, but instead *entire ideas*, adding up each of the three corresponding attributes. In addition, a special attack applies one elemental effect of the attacker's choice from that idea regardless of their elemental affinity: a bravery special applies fire or water's unique elemental effect, or the shared elemental effect Invigorating Steam; a justice special attack applies light or dark's unique elemental effect or the shared elemental effect Blinding Eclipse; and so on. Remember that elemental effects with durations based on the attack's net successes have a maximum duration of six.

A basic special attack allows the attacker to roll one idea and apply one elemental effect therefrom. With successive special attacks in combination, however, Bearers and Blades come together to unleash the total of their shared ability. A level two combination special attack allows the attacker and their partner (one partner, in the case of a Bearer with two Blades) to each roll the same idea, and the attacker chooses one elemental effect corresponding to that idea. A level three combination special lets the attacker and their partner each roll an idea of their choice and apply one elemental effect from either.

Special attacks have infinite range, though they require the attacker to be able to see the target like any other attack. Special attacks cannot be dodged, and as there is no defense roll against a special, the number of successes the attacker (and their partner in a combination special attack) rolls becomes the amount of damage dealt as well as the potency of invoked effects. While a level one special attack is single target, level two and three combination specials can have their damage total split among any number of chosen targets in a 3x3 and 5x5 square area respectively.

With the sheer power available in special attacks, it's critical that you use them to your advantage in combat. Fight with your friends as hard as you can for the values you both hold, as non-player characters may have other abilities or devastating attacks designed by the Architect not described in this section of the book.

HP and Falling in Battle

Actions and effects in combat deal damage, reducing a target's HP from its maximum towards zero, and sometimes restore lost HP as well. As explained in chapter 3, one's maximum HP is willpower + stamina + 4 (plus any bonuses gained from talents); this section details what happens when a combatant runs out. When a combatant, Bearer, Blade, or otherwise, is reduced to 0 HP or less, they fall unconscious and are removed from the battle, unable to return. In addition to having their own health, however, Blades also depend on their connection to their Bearer to stay in the fight. When a Blade's Bearer falls unconscious, **they are also instantly reduced to zero HP** and removed from combat along with their Bearer.

Due to the connection Blades share with their Bearers, however, there is a last line of defense when a Bearer is defeated: when a Bearer takes damage that brings them to 0 or less HP, their Blade can use **Life Force Sharing**, paying their own HP to restore their Bearer from that damage to any positive HP value. Doing so costs the Blade one additional point of health that does not go to the Bearer. If the Blade chooses not to share, lacks sufficient HP, or is otherwise unable to do this, the Bearer and Blade are both removed from battle.

Triage tip: As Blades cannot remain in combat with an unconscious Bearer, keeping one's Bearer up and fighting must be a Blade's highest priority. However, funneling life force into a Bearer is not the only way to ward off defeat. Certain tags and talents have the ability to raise standing players' HP, and the Blade talent Protective Aegis (48) allows Blades to share their HP with their Bearers freely and without cost.

When a material combatant such as a Bearer hits 0 HP, they fall unconscious due to the strain of their injuries. Since the only way to truly kill a Blade is to shatter their core, Blades carry an instinctual defense mechanism that activates when they are too injured to reliably defend themselves or do not have the stable etheric connection with their Bearer required to use their powers. This instinct sacrifices their manifested body to refocus their natural energy towards protecting their core from harm and restoring their etheric constitution. A Blade in temporary core form cannot interact with the outside world and is not conscious. The core is shielded by an etheric barrier that is extremely difficult, but not impossible, to break through.

There is no way for a combatant who falls unconscious to re-enter that battle. Time for rest and, if damage is severe, proper care for Bearers is required for players' HP to be restored. There is no numbered amount of time or rest to return players to full HP, however, and when players gain their HP back is left up to the Architect. Restoration should follow the fiction rather than dictate it. Did a badly injured Bearer receive medical attention? Did the party's Blades have sufficient calm time to regenerate? Let the story decide. In general, though, characters' HP should be fully restored between battles unless they occur with absolutely no time to spare.

Tenacity tip: In the world of Blades of Ether, one's determination to stay in the fight is just as important as one's good health. As a combatant falls closer to 0 HP, they may become injured, yes, but their sheer will to keep fighting means no pain will slow them down.

Play Tips: On Violence and Killing

This game focuses very heavily on combat, fighting, and bonds forged on the battlefield. This means that combat *will* occur, and relatively frequently. This is alright, though. Fighting is not always something to avoid. The important thing is that the tone is kept focused. You are not going to be enacting violence, you are engaging in combat.

Combat is exciting and dramatic, with powers blazing and hearts soaring as the music reaches a crescendo. Violence, on the other hand, is grounded, terrifying, and final, leaving permanent wounds and emotional harm. You can have combat without violence, and you can have violence without combat. Know when you are fighting and when you are just inflicting violence upon others. When pointed in the right direction, a sword is a powerful tool that can help people, make a better world, and topple those who see themselves as gods. Violence only serves to hurt the characters in the world, and if lines of comfort are not properly discussed, it can hurt the players, too.

This doesn't mean you should avoid violence at all times. Villains will enact violence, and your characters may choose to enact violence in a misguided moment. But this is not a game that revels in bloodshed. You should discuss with everyone where the lines are, and when violence does happen, paint it with a broad brush and describe it vaguely or not at all, avoiding specific injuries and details.

Teammate tension tip: What happens in player vs. player combat? While combat is designed for player characters to fight against non-player characters, the rules as written should allow inter-team player character conflict, though it will be significantly both slower and more complex. Combat within a team may not be possible without major adjustments to the rules which are outside of the scope of this book. If player characters get into a fight, we recommend settling such a dispute with out-of-combat dice rolls or even entirely free-form, diceless roleplay. Remember that bonds and affinity exist to mark the way characters relate to each other, and should be used before resorting to adapting other mechanics. Blades of Ether is a cooperative game first and foremost, a shared story of how one's bonds with those they care about affect them and help them grow.

The numeric HP rules say nothing of death. When a player character reduces a non-player combatant's HP to 0, whether they strike a lethal or simply defeating blow is up to their player. While this should follow the fiction to a degree (taking overtly lethal actions like pushing someone over a cliff or into a pool of molten metal should appropriately lead to death), a higher number of successes on an attack roll means more precision, a more perfect execution of the character's intentions, not simply a more powerful and deadly strike. If the result of a finishing attack is in doubt, the

Architect and player should discuss their intentions and the results thereof before, not after, the damage is applied.

Killing a player character is an act of extreme narrative significance, and does not occur in the normal flow of combat. **No one, not even the Architect, may kill a player character except their player.** At any time, if you feel compelled to do so, you can take complete control of the narrative from the Architect for the moments leading up to your character's demise. What happens next is completely up to you: go out in a blaze of glory, sacrifice your life to achieve the impossible, make yourself vulnerable to land the perfect strike and rend your ultimate enemy, finally achieve your true goal, turn unbeatable odds to your party's favor, or do all of the above, and then describe your character's death.

Typical Blades are functionally immortal and cannot die unless their core is shattered, but a Blade loses all of their memories and retreats into their core when their Bearer dies, laying dormant until a new Bearer forges them. To most Blades, this is tantamount to death, and as such, a natural Blade's player must agree to go out along with their Bearer.

Action in Action

This section presents a complete example of combat with our familiar hypothetical party.

It's time for combat, so Architect Tori tells Ren, Mia, Morgan, and Zeke to roll initiative. Partners Ren and Mia roll a 3 and a 5 respectively, and Morgan and Zeke roll a 1 and a 3. Pyre's calculation + experience is higher than Pandora's, so Pyre's team gets the higher slot in the tie. As the enemy Bearer and Blade's initiatives are 2 and 4, the turn order is Pyre/Doma, Enemy Bearer, Bridget/Pandora, Pyre/Doma, Enemy Blade, and finally Bridget/Pandora. Mia and Morgan decide to go first in their teams, so the turn order is set: Doma, Blade, Bridget, Pyre, Bearer, Pandora.

A few turns in, Pyre is up. After moving into place, she decides to use her art "Spinning Blade" on the enemy Bearer with the tags Potency +1, Range 2, Break, and Side Attack. Ren turns Pyre's token towards the enemy Bearer and sets a die showing a 6 on the art's square. Tori asks Ren to describe Pyre's attack, and Ren says Pyre tries to follow up on the attack dealt by Bridget last turn and hit the Bearer again before they can regain their composure. Tori tells Ren to roll swiftness without Pyre's Side Attack bonus, as the enemy Blade is in position to intercept her. With a swiftness of 4, Ren rolls 5 dice (thanks to Spinning Blade's Potency +1 tag), and gets 3 successes. Tori says this hits with 1 net success, meaning the Bearer is broken.

Ren turns the enemy Bearer's token towards Pyre, turns his team's current special die from 2 to 3, and turns Spinning Blade's cooldown die to 5 along with Pyre's other active cooldown die from 3 to 2. Ren moves Pyre's turn order token to the bottom of the list, and Pyre's turn is over.

Next is the enemy Blade's turn. The Blade moves out a radius, and Tori moves their token to the other side of the new circle, putting them a few squares from Bridget and Pandora, who are still near each other. Tori says the Blade is using a line attack art called "Shadow Stretch." Tori turns their token and then describes the art, saying they raise their chroma-lance into the air and unleash a beam of darkness, which forms into a massive fist and slams down through 5 squares in front of them, and then asks Bridget and Pandora, both in the line of fire, how they react. Morgan says Bridget looks around, identifies a suitable nearby rock, and uses one of her whip-swords to pull herself towards it. Zeke, laughing boisterously, declares that Pandora simply blocks the attack with her greatsword. Tori tells Morgan to roll calculation, and Zeke to roll might at a -2 to physically block a magical strike.

Morgan rolls Bridget's calculation of 4, getting 2 successes, and Pandora's might of 3 results in 1 success. Tori says Bridget's plan just barely works, but Pandora isn't so lucky. She takes 1 damage and the elemental effect Shadow Manipulation with a duration of 1, meaning Tori will choose her attack target on her upcoming turn. Since Bridget and Pandora's defenses were a near hit and near miss respectively, Tori takes both of these into account and says that Bridget's whip-strike shattered her target rock, making that square untraversable because of the debris. Zeke marks Pandora's damage and sets aside a die with a 1 showing to track the Shadow Manipulation effect. Tori moves the enemy Blade's turn order token to the bottom of the list and turns both Bridget and Pandora's tokens to face the enemy Blade.

A number of rounds of combat pass, and it is now Doma's turn. Pyre and Bridget have successfully backed the enemy pair up against a wall, and Mia intends to take full advantage. Pandora used a special attack a few rounds ago, which means the next special to be used has to be a level 2 special, but Pyre's last successful attack earned the team their second full special die! Mia says she'd like to use their level 2 special attack, and Ren agrees. Tori asks Mia what Doma does. Given that these enemies were robbing a local village, Mia says, Doma performs a special attack based on justice, targeting the square between them with a 3x3 circle attack, and Tori and Ren both agree. Mia and Ren roll each of their characters' justice attributes (swiftness, improvisation, and passion), and Mia picks justice's shared elemental effect, Blinding Eclipse. The teammates roll and generate a total of 10 successes between them. Mia decides to split the damage evenly, dealing 5 damage and Blinding Eclipse for 5 turns to each enemy.

The party cheers, but after removing the enemy Blade's token from the map, Tori grins menacingly, because this Bearer has a unique ability they can only use once their Blade is defeated...

Chapter 5: Character Creation and Progression

It is said that every Blade and Bearer can feel the exact moment when the journey that would go on to define their story begins. For some, a whirlwind of adventure swept them off their feet at the moment of forging. For others, the true start wouldn't make itself clear for decades. No matter the circumstances, it is important that one uses that moment to reflect on who they are and who they might become.

In order to explore this world, you will, of course, need to create a Blade or Bearer as a vehicle to experience it through. *Blades of Ether* revolves around the bonds you have with your party, so it is strongly recommended you communicate with the other players during the character creation process, especially the one who will play your partner. In order to build characters, you will need a character sheet, which can be printed from the [end of the book](#) or found [online](#).

Character Creation

The first thing you must do is establish basic information about your character. What are your name and pronouns? What do you look like? Are you a Blade or a Bearer? What kind of personality do you have? What does your bond weapon look like? What have you done with your life before now? Once you have answers to these questions, choose another player to be your partner. One of you will be a Blade and the other a Bearer. If your campaign starts with Blades already forged, when and why did the Bearer forge their Blade, knowing how dangerous forging is? Note that a Bearer may have two Blades, although it is recommended you only form a team of three when there are an odd number of players. If you are looking for inspiration, it might be a good idea to look through [chapter 6](#) now, as many talents could serve as good starting point for a character. Fill out the top of your character sheet.

Starting Point

How long have you been traveling for? How formidable are you in a fight? Is this journey the next in a long string, or are you anxious at this new opportunity? The answers to these questions are key to the type of adventure the Architect has crafted for you, and therefore, should be determined by the level of strength they ask you to start with. There are four categories your character might fit into: fresh face, part-time hero, veteran, or titan savior. Which one you are asked to start as will determine how many points you get to spend strengthening your character, but it should also reflect how accomplished they are in their background. Note that these categories are only suggestions, and the Architect may ask you to start with different point totals.

Tagalong tip: If you're making a PC to join an in-progress campaign, perform character creation as directed here using the same starting points that your new party did. Once that's done, the Architect will give you bond points equal to what each existing PC has received so far in the campaign, which you can use to grow your character to match the party. Don't forget to think about what your character might have been through to earn all those bond points!

Attributes

The raw strength of a Blade or Bearer can be measured in their 12 attributes: might, willpower, calculation, gut, experience, knowledge, stamina, empathy, attunement, swiftness, improvisation, and passion. Attributes are discussed in detail in [chapter 3](#).

Fresh face: Allot 8 points.

Veteran: Allot 24 points.

Part-time hero: Allot 16 points.

Titan savior: Allot 32 points.

Each attribute starts at rank 1. At character creation, ranks 2–4 cost 1 point each, ranks 5–8 cost 2 points, and ranks 9–12 cost 3. Attributes cannot be raised above 12. Spend all allotted points now.

Elemental Affinity

Beneath a character's attributes is space for their elemental affinities, which are discussed on [page 9](#). At character creation, circle one of the eight elements to have an affinity for. If you're unsure which to choose, you could pick one aligned with the idea that best embodies your character, or one with an elemental effect that suits how you want to fight, which can be reviewed on [page 25](#).

While a Blade's elemental affinity reflects their etheric body's natural attunement, for Bearers, elemental affinity reflects the bond you have with your Blade, so discuss with your partner when choosing. Note that no element has only one obvious meaning for a bond. Fire, for example, could represent anything from the flames of passion born from rivalry to the warming bonfire of romantic love; darkness could represent a clouded, troubled relationship just as easily as it could represent a friendship as calming as looking at the night sky; and water embodies its life-giving properties as well as the ferocious, unstoppable rush of a rapid river.

Bravery: fire or water.

Truth: earth or electricity.

Compassion: wind or ice.

Justice: light or dark.

Traits

The box directly above the attributes box has a character's four traits. The effects of traits are discussed in [chapter 4](#), but can be determined with what you have now:

Basic Attack Range: 1.

Initiative: The higher of improvisation + gut or calculation + experience.

Maximum HP: Willpower + stamina + 4.

Movement: 3 for Bearers, 1 for Blades.

Field Skills

Directly below the attributes box are your field skills. Field skills are disciplines, crafts, hobbies, or other non-combat practices that you excel at or enjoy. For more information on them, see [page 14](#). Use these free skills to flesh out your character!

First, take the free field skill “Elemental Mastery,” which reflects the instinctive ability all beings have to manipulate ether aligned with their elemental affinities with a great degree of control and precision.

Fresh face: Write 2 field skills.

Veteran: Write 4 field skills.

Part-time hero: Write 3 field skills.

Titan savior: Write 5 field skills.

Bonds

On the bottom of the front of the character sheet are your bonds with your fellow party members. Write the names of each of your party members under “name.” Your bond with each player comes in four parts: the bond’s name or descriptor, an advantage and drawback to your interactions, and your affinity ranking, which ranges from -2 to 2. Details on the bond system and examples are on [page 9](#).

If any characters in the party already know each other, their players may write bonds for them before beginning gameplay. Define bonds for every other relationship based on your impressions after your first gameplay session. The nature of bonds can and should change over time! Then, circle the current closeness within each of your bonds on the affinity scale of -2 to +2 (most affinities will start at 0). It is recommended that your affinities average out to 0 at character creation, but affinities should chiefly match the narrative.

Trackers

The box on the top-right of the character sheet holds a number of trackers that will come in handy. There are checkboxes for the availability of the once-per-arc special abilities I’m Really Feeling It, It’s Reyn Time, and The Heronop Special ([page 13](#)), and three spots for dice for your team’s special dice ([page 27](#)).

Arts

The three boxes on the right side of the front of the character sheet are for your arts. You can use the dice slot in each art’s area to track their cooldowns. The effects of your arts are determined by the tags you buy for them. Once you’ve picked your tags, you’re encouraged to name and describe each of your arts. For information on tag effects and arts in general, see [page 22](#).

First, apply a free Potency +1 tag to each of your three arts.

Fresh face: For each art, choose 2 tags, with no more than 1 tag per category.

Part-time hero: For each art, choose 4 tags, with no more than 2 tags per category.

Veteran: For each art, choose 6 arts tags, with no more than 2 tags per category.

Titan Savior: For each art, choose 8 tags, with no more than 3 tags per category.

Note that **selecting an area of effect category tag uses up 3 tags, and the Precise Attack tag uses up 2**. Remember that you may only take more than one distinct tag from the fundamentals category, that Precise Attack and Range +1 do not count as being in the same category, and that you may only take a tag multiple times if it has a maximum quantity listed.

Art 1

Anchor Toss

Description

Pulls the enemy down with a hook on a rope

Healing Potion

Topple

Potency

+ 1

Cooldown

- 0

Range

+ 2

An example art.

Art tags at character creation					
Fundamentals	Area of Effect	Reactions	Positionals	Elemental Effects	Other
Cost 1	Cost 3	Cost 1	Cost 1	Cost 1, requires affinity	Cost varies
Potency +1 Max 5	Circle Attack Max 2	Break	Side Advantage Bearers only	Unique Elem. Effect Any element	Range +1 Cost 1 Max 5
Healing Potion	Line Attack	Topple	Rear Advantage Bearers only	Invigorating Steam Fire or water	Precise Attack Cost 2
Cooldown -1 Max 2		Launch	Pincer Attack Blades only	Bitter Snowstorm Wind or ice	
		Stagger		Counter Spike Earth or electricity	
		Rush Max 2		Blinding Eclipse Light or dark	

Talents

On the back of your character sheet, there are a number of empty boxes for writing down your talents. Talents are either special actions you've learned how to do or qualities inherent to you. You'll notice that there are two boxes in the corner of each talent slot. The first box is for noting if a talent is useable once per arc, once per session or once per combat; simply put A, S, or C in the box if so. The second box is for tracking whether these limited-use talents have been used in the current arc, session, or combat. These boxes can be left blank for other talents. For the full list of talents, see [chapter 6](#). Be aware that some talents may only be acquired at character creation. If you want any of those, make sure to take them now!

Fresh face: Acquire talents with total rank 5.

Veteran: Acquire talents with total rank 11.

Part-time hero: Acquire talents with total rank 8.

Titan savior: Acquire talents with total rank 14.

Inventory and Notes

Blades of Ether does not have you track resources like money and basic supplies. If it's reasonable for you to be able to afford or have something, you have it. If it isn't, you'll need to find another way to get what you need or do without it. Weapons, similarly, are something inherent to the bond between Bearer and Blade, so these are also not tracked here. The inventory section on your character sheet, therefore, is meant for tracking important, specific items. For example, if you find an odd book or a mysterious device during your travels, you can write it down here. This section can also be used to write down any important notes for your game!

The Dead Box

At the top of your character sheet is a checkbox labeled the "dead box." You can mark this box at any time to take control of the narrative from the Architect and bring a meaningful end to your character's life should you choose to. As discussed on [page 31](#), not even the Architect may kill your character otherwise.

Of course, once a character's dead box is filled, that character is **removed from the game permanently**, and that player will have to create a new character to continue playing. A Blade's player may choose to have their previous Blade be forged by a new Bearer if their core is intact, but character creation should still be started over. A different Bearer can have significant effect on the appearance, personality, and skills of the same core, and, shorn of their memories, a Blade may develop completely different mechanical abilities such as arts.

Character Creation Starting Points				
	Attributes	Field skills	Arts	Talents
	1 point allows you to increase an attribute by 1. Ranks above 4 cost 2 points. Ranks above 8 cost 3 points.	Field skills do not come in tiered rankings, so create the suggested number of skills.	Start with a free Potency +1 tag. You have a number of tags per art to claim, but can only spend so much in any one category. Taking a tag from the area of effect category counts as 3 tags, and taking the Precise Attack tag counts as 2.	Acquire talents whose total rank equals the number listed below.
Fresh face	8 points	2 field skills	2 tags, max 1/cat.	5 ranks
Part-time hero	16 points	3 field skills	4 tags, max 2/cat.	8 ranks
Veteran	24 points	4 field skills	6 tags, max 2/cat.	11 ranks
Titan savior	32 points	5 field skills	8 tags, max 3/cat.	14 ranks

Progression and Bond Points

The true strengths of Bearers and Blades come not from having the largest sword or best plans, but from the relationships they have with their allies. Therefore, in order to increase your attributes, become proficient in new field skills, enhance your arts, or learn new talents, you will need **Bond Points**, or **BP**. At the end of a gameplay session, you'll tell the Architect about how your character played into or evolved their bonds with others. For each bond the Architect feels was meaningfully altered or explored, they will award one BP to each of the corresponding player characters. If a bond between partners is chosen, the partners each receive an additional BP. A Bearer with two Blades may only receive this extra BP once per session, even if they earned BP with both of their partner Blades. In addition to any BP gained this way from roleplaying, every player who attended the session should receive 1 free BP. Bond points are tracked at the top of your character sheet.

Familiar examples Ren, Mia, Morgan, Zeke, and Tori have just finished an action-filled session and are getting ready to stop for the night. Tori announces that it is time to distribute bond points. Mia says Doma unveiled a secret to Pyre, which caused Pyre to develop a deeper trust in him. Tori awards Pyre and Doma 2 BP, as they are partners. They are asked to rewrite their bond to express this new trust. Mia also had Doma's long-standing rivalry with Bridget flare up this session, causing them to have a huge fight over who should get to lead the charge on the enemy. Tori agrees that this is a sufficient show of their bond, and awards them each 1 BP, as they are not partners. Zeke says Pyre and Pandora went fishing together during some downtime and had fun. Tori says this interaction did not play into or reshape their mentor-mentee bond, and they are not granted any BP. No other character pairs had significant interactions, so no further bonds were touched on, and the session ends after all four party members are awarded 1 BP for playing.

Between sessions, you may spend any BP you've accumulated over the course of the game. Generally, the more you upgrade something, the more expensive it gets to upgrade. For the specific costs of upgrades you can acquire, refer to this table:

Upgrade Bond Points Costs	
Attribute	2 × new rank
Elemental affinity	7 × new total number of affinities
Field skill	3 per field skill
Talent	3 × talent rank
Basic attack range	2 × new total bonus range (maximum 5)
Categorized arts tag	Cat. cost × new number of tags in that category on that art
Other arts tag	Precise Attack: 10; Range +1: 2 × new total bonus range

Here are some example bond point costs:

Raising might from 6 to 7:
 $2 \text{ (base cost)} \times 7 \text{ (new rank)} = 14 \text{ BP}$

Gaining a third elemental affinity:
 $7 \text{ (base cost)} \times 3 \text{ (new total)} = 21 \text{ BP}$

Learning the rank 6 talent Opportunist:
 $3 \text{ (base cost)} \times 6 \text{ (talent rank)} = 18 \text{ BP}$

Putting Healing Potion on an art that has
3 Potency +1 tags and Cooldown -1
(plus any other non-fundamentals tags):
 $3 \text{ (category cost)} \times 5 \text{ (new total number of fundamentals tags)} = 15 \text{ BP}$

Increasing your basic attack range to 4:
 $2 \text{ (base)} \times 3 \text{ (new bonus range)} = 6 \text{ BP}$

Characters may not “skip” BP costs by raising a characteristic by multiple levels at once. To raise an attribute from 3 to 5, for example, a character must first pay 8 BP to raise that attribute to rank 4, then 10 BP to raise it to rank 5.

Some talents such as Fame and Infamy can be acquired at a variety of ranks, granting greater levels of effect at higher ranks. These talents can be upgraded over time by paying for additional ranks. Improving one of these talents from rank 2 to rank 4, for example, would cost 6 BP, or 3 BP for rank 3 and 3 BP for rank 4.

Refunding Arts Tags

Building an art that feels exactly the way you want it can be a tricky thing, and you may wind up changing your mind as to which tags you want on it. At the end of each story arc, you may choose to refund one tag, losing the tag and regaining the experience it cost to buy the most recent tag in that category. This means if you bought a Potency +1 tag for 6 BP but have since bought a Cooldown -1 tag for that art, giving you 3 total tags in that category, you would get 9 BP for refunding that tag. You are allowed to refund the Potency +1 tags each of your arts start with, but only after the first arc.

Chapter 6: List of Talents

Whether learned or instinctual, every Bearer and Blade has a number of talents they make use of in their journeys. What they are and how they're applied can be the difference between legends and footnotes.

As described earlier in the book, talents are unique traits and abilities that bolster a Bearer or Blade's strengths, shore up their weaknesses, or give them new powers altogether. Talents are divided in a number of categories: universal talents, Bearer talents, Blade talents, **Pair Talents**, and **Archetype Talents**. These are further divided into general and combat-specific talents. Note that some talents have prerequisites, including acquisition of other talents and ranks in certain attributes; additionally, some talents are only available at character creation. Each talent has a **Rank** which represents how potent it is; acquiring a new talent costs $3 \times$ talent rank BP. Excepting talents that can be upgraded to higher ranks, talents can only be acquired once.

Universal Talents

Blade, Bearer, or neither, these talents can be learned by anyone, but don't let that fool you. Sometimes, no amount of ether can stand up to a clever maneuver or a friendly smile.

General

Social Butterfly (Rank 4)

People are naturally friendly towards you unless they have a reason not to be.

Fame (Rank 1-10)

Be it for your deeds, your work, or just because you're *that* cute, you're well known somewhere across the Cloud Sea. In any place where you're a household name, people are more likely to offer you aid, privileges, deals, or service. Higher ranks of this ability award more fame.

Infamy (Rank 1-10)

Whether you had to make a difficult choice, you did something unpopular, or you're just plain evil, people know they hate you. They're likely to be afraid of you, often avoiding you and more easily giving in to your threats. Higher ranks of this ability award more infamy.

Troublemaker (Rank 3)

At any time, you are able to declare that someone in the room, for some reason, hates you. The Architect will tell you which person. Describe the reason why.

Friend of Nature (Rank 2)

Requires 4 empathy

Animals innately feel comfortable around you. Timid animals will not flee in your presence, and aggressive animals will not attack you unless provoked.

Use Five Words When One Would Do (Rank 2)

When you use your eloquent way of speech and strange affectations for communication, you might confuse or mislead your conversational partner, giving you +1 to any related rolls.

Natural Leader (Rank 6)

When you give orders to someone who does not know you, they will listen to you, assuming you probably know what you're talking about, so long as your order is within the realm of believability.

Pouch of Goodies (Rank 2)

You carry a supply of small trinkets and treats, and have a good sense for who might like them. At any time, you may ask the Architect what sort of small gift a character might like, and they will answer honestly. So long as you've kept your pouch stocked, you have just the thing to win them over!

I'm Not Sure About Rain, Though (Rank 1)

You have an innate sense of the weather and always know what tomorrow's will bring.

Wanderer's Sense (Rank 3)

Requires 5 gut

You have an innate sense of direction... sort of. When you choose a direction and walk in it, relying solely on instinct, you may or may not end up where you intended to go, but you will definitely wind up somewhere interesting.

Ricky Likes Fighting Easy Monsters (Rank 3)

You can always tell how strong an enemy is relative to you.

Play the Stage (Rank 1)

If you need a particular outfit or costume for something, you always have it. Similarly, if you need an environmental object as a prop, it will be there if reasonable.

I Like You, Kid (Rank 3)

Requires 4 passion

When you fail to convince someone non-hostile to aid you in something you deeply care about, your honesty still gets through to them. Although they will not do what you ask, they will give you some concession.

Like a Mirror (Rank 4)

You always know if someone is lying to you.

Devil's Own Luck (Rank 3)

You've got amazing luck, while everyone else around you finds themselves with the opposite.

Friends Now! (Rank 3)

When you beat someone in a fight, you are able to declare that you two have become friends, of sorts. Perhaps not good friends, but at the very least, you can see eye to eye.

General Sense of Things (Rank 2)

If something doesn't make sense, feels unusual, or is a logical inconsistency, you can tell something's off. You don't inherently know what, but you can roll to find out..

Interpersonal Deduction (Rank 2)

Requires 4 empathy

Once per arc, you may ask the Architect how one character feels about another. The Architect will answer honestly.

Unsubtle and Undetected (Rank 4)

Despite whatever unmistakable features you may have, it only takes one special accessory for you to blend in, whether it be a pair of stylish specs, an unremarkable cloak, or something else entirely.

To Make Heads or Tails (Rank 2)

When you take this talent, choose two arbitrary, opposing, and specific categories (such as dog-favoring or cat-favoring, lawful or chaotic, fire or ice). If unclear, you may explain what you mean by them. When you meet a new person, you may ask the Architect which category they would fit more closely into. They will answer honestly; describe why you feel this way.

I Meant to Do That (Rank 3)

Requires 4 improvisation

When you fail a roll outside of combat, if you can quickly think of a way to use the resulting fallout to your advantage, you may roll again. If you succeed, you are guaranteed to have no negative consequences for the original roll. If you fail, however, you'll face double the consequences.

Shadowrunner (Rank 2)

You know how to blend in, gaining +2 to rolls for avoiding detection or being identified.

Imposing (Rank 3)

Whether due to an intimidating demeanor or ominous reputation, you are an inherently frightening figure. When you make a threat, you gain +2 to convince your target to acquiesce. However, if your roll fails, you *must* follow through on your threat to uphold your reputation.

I Love You...and All You Guys! (Rank 6)

Once per arc, you may reduce a +2 affinity to a 0. If you do, increase your affinity with all other party member by 1. Explain what you did to cause this shift.

Just a Flesh Wound (Rank 10)

One time after taking this talent, you may cross this Talent out. After doing so, act as if you have filled your dead box, temporarily taking control of the narrative from the Architect to make what appears to be the ultimate sacrifice. However, thanks to a miracle (or, perhaps, an ingenious plan) you survive. You cannot refresh, repurchase, or reuse this talent ever. You might choose to hide the fact that you have this talent from other players if you like, but your partner will likely have to know.

The Next Thing You're Going to Say Is... (Rank 4)

Requires 5 calculation

Once per arc, you may ask the Architect what someone is going to do in the immediate future, allowing you to formulate a plan to use this knowledge to your advantage. You may do this in or out of combat.

Emotional Ties (Rank 2)

You can truly feel the bonds you share with the people around you. Whenever you are at +2 affinity with someone, you know where they are at all times, even if you cannot see them.

Building Through Conflict (Rank 3)

You're a pretty argumentative person, but somehow, it never seems to get in the way. Take no teamwork penalty when at -1 affinity, and only a -1 penalty at -2 affinity.

Mascot Character (Rank 2)

A small, lovable creature has joined you and your companions! It is not sentient and cannot speak your language, but it's rather intelligent nonetheless, and manages to get its point across in simple noises and gestures. The creature is etheric in nature, and as it grows it may change and evolve in unexpected ways. When you take this talent, choose one of the following options for your mascot, and name and describe the creature you've bonded with. If another player already has this talent, purchasing it lets you give the party's mascot an additional ability and describe how its appearance changes with its new evolution. The Architect controls the mascot's behavior, and it may not always be inclined to help you. You cannot take this talent more than once.

Good Instincts: Your mascot has refined natural instincts and a good sense for sentient behavior, letting it intervene to prevent a foolhardy course of action.

Eyes in The Sky: Your mascot's keen eyes and ability to fly allow for it to soar far above the ground and communicate to you a very general description of the surrounding area.

Just the Cutest: Your mascot is just so endearing to sentient beings. That loveable ball of fur might help you in a spat or tense situation!

Natural Scavenger: Your mascot's sharp senses and refined instincts allow it to find food and valuable trinkets in the wild. Just don't let it loose in a busy market!

One With the Hunt: While your mascot will not fight by your side, it knows how to stay alive in the wild, and may sometimes aid you in battle.

Titan-in-Training: Your mascot, a naturally etheric being, is in tune with the Titans, and can aid you in etheric pursuits and has generally good ether-sense.

Combat

Immovable Gonzalez (Rank 3)

When someone is launched into you, you take no damage and are not broken. The launched person acts as though you were a wall, stopping in front of you and taking collision damage.

Vendetta (Rank 3)

When you take this talent, name one person. Whenever someone hurts that person in any way, take +1 to your next action against them.

Power Dive (Rank 3)

Once per combat, you hit the deck to successfully dodge an attack. You cannot move or attack on your next turn, but until the end of your following turn, you have +1 to all actions.

Switch Art (Rank 2)

Once per combat, you may use one of your partner's arts so long as it is ready. If you do, you swap weapons with them, trading access for each other's arts and basic attack ranges. This effect ends when your partner uses one of your arts.

Crisis Catalyst (Rank 2)

When you are at or below one quarter of your maximum HP, rounded down, gain +2 to all attack rolls.

Desperate Defense (Rank 2)

When you are at or below one quarter of your maximum HP, rounded down, gain +2 to all defense rolls.

Secondary Accelerator (Rank 3)

Reduce one of your starting arts cooldowns by two at the beginning of combat.

Prime Position (Rank 5)

Requires Secondary Accelerator

Reduce one additional starting arts cooldown by two, meaning you start with two arts ready and one two turns away.

Grand Procession (Rank 5)

You strike with a charisma that raises your party's morale. When you use a special attack, all other teams receive two special points.

Tactical Delay (Rank 1)

At any time, you may move yourself down in the turn order by any number.

The Last Laugh (Rank 4)

Once per combat, if you have at least one full special die, you may perform as your action a first level special attack regardless of the current special attack combination. This attack consumes all of your team's special points. After using this talent, your team cannot gain any special points for the rest of this combat.

Rematch (Rank 1)

If you are fighting someone who bested you in a previous encounter, you automatically get to start at the top of the turn order.

Rigid Shield (Rank 2)

On any turn you do not use an offensive action, you use your weapon to block. Before your next turn, you may protect yourself or a party member within your basic attack range from any one attack, granting +1 to that defense roll.

What Goes Around... (Rank 7)

Gain 1 special point whenever you take damage.

Dirty Fighter (Rank 1)

Basic attacks and arts deal one additional damage to toppled targets if you are within one square of the target. You may not move after attacking with this bonus.

Point Blank (Rank 2)

Once per combat, you may reduce the range of one of your arts or your basic attack to 1 until the end of this turn. If you do, it gains a dice pool bonus equal to its normal range for this turn's attack.

Eagle Eye (Rank 2)

Once per combat, you may execute an art or basic attack beyond its normal range. Doing so incurs a dice pool penalty equal to the number of squares the attack's maximum range is extended to. You cannot extend the range of your attack beyond the point where its dice pool falls to 1 die.

Exit Strategy (Rank 9)

Requires 8 calculation

Once per arc, when the party has been completely defeated, you've already come up with a contingency plan and manage to get everyone to safety. Explain your plan after the fact.

Vanguard (Rank 3)

Once per combat, you may give your turn to your partner.

No...Not Yet! (Rank 8)

Requires 7 willpower

Right before you are knocked unconscious, you steel your resolve for a final effort. If you will be reduced to zero HP and removed from battle, unleash a level two special attack regardless of the current special attack chain before falling unconscious. If your partner is already unconscious, you roll your chosen idea's attributes twice. If this non-lethally defeats the last enemy, you will return to consciousness before they do.

Your Patience, Their Penitence (Rank 7)

If one or more of your arts is off cooldown at the end of your turn, gain one special point.

First Strike (Rank 3)

You gain +3 to initiative rolls.

Indomitable (Rank 2)

Increase your max HP by 2.

Fortified (Rank 4)

Increase your max HP by 4.

Steel Flesh (Rank 6)

Increase your max HP by 6.

Opportunist (Rank 6)

When a fight starts, you are always behind an opponent of your choice. You may describe how you got there, or leave it to mystery.

THINK YOU CAN TAKE ME? (Rank 6)

Once per combat, you may let loose a loud battle cry, startling everyone not on your team and forcing them back by 1 in the turn order.

Villain's Monologue (Rank 4)

Requires 4 calculation

After you roll initiative, you may deliver an enthralling speech about your grand scheme. No one is allowed to make a move while you talk. Once you are finished, everyone except for you rerolls initiative. As your plan has been exposed, you are moved to the end of the turn order. You may not use this talent if you have been ambushed.

Say Sorry (Rank 5)

Whenever you deal damage to a target without inflicting an elemental effect on them, you may remove all negative elemental effects currently applied to them. If you do this, you inflict 2 additional damage per effect removed.

Healer (Rank 1)

When you use an art, instead of attacking a target with it, you may roll unopposed to heal yourself or an ally for HP equivalent to the number of successes on your roll. For the rest of this combat, you may only use the effect of this talent with the same art you used. When you heal in this way, you must also reset the cooldown of a ready art or, if neither other art is ready, the art with the lowest current cooldown die.

Elite Healer (Rank 5)

Requires Healer

Healer now targets a full team instead of only one ally.

Master Healer (Rank 7)

Requires Elite Healer

Healer now targets all allies instead of only one team.

Bearer Talents

Maintaining the etheric bond with their Blade is something that comes naturally to a Bearer, but manipulating that ether is a skill that has thousand different forms from a million different paths to mastery.

General

Old Friends (Rank 1)

Whether inseparable since childhood or near-strangers from the far side of town, you've made allies you can call on. When you take this talent, name a person or group of people from your past. You can call on them for aid within the bounds of their skills and trust in you. You may take this talent multiple times, naming a different friend or group each time.

Sidearm (Rank 3)

You have an additional Blade gifted in long-range operation. They won't fight alongside you in combat, but you may send them off to accomplish tasks such as spying on an enemy, guarding an area, or making a delivery. This Blade is their own person, of course, and is under no obligation to listen.

Bond Sever (Rank 4)

Requires 3 attunement

After knocking a Bearer unconscious, you may choose to permanently cut their connection with their Blade, reverting it to an unbonded core. Many consider this murder, but you're not afraid to do what needs to be done.

They Were Here the Whole Time! (Rank 4)

If you are in a scene and your Blade is not present, you may declare at any time that they, in fact, have not only been there the entire time, but are acting on a plan you two devised in secret beforehand.

Titan Driver (Rank 10)

You know the cycle of life: Blades, after enough lifetimes, become Titans, who birth new Blades. With this knowledge, you have discovered that the Blade within allows you, if only temporarily, to bond with a Titan. Once per arc, you may issue one command to the nearest Titan, and they will listen unless it would do severe harm to them.

Brought From Home (Rank 3)

The Titan you come from is so distant that it's unlikely anyone you encounter on your travels will have even heard of it, much less have visited. As a result, you have a piece of technology or scientific information that no one nearby is remotely familiar with. Discuss what this is with the Architect when you take this talent.

Steel Stomach (Rank 2)

Requires 4 stamina

You can eat pretty much anything. Whether it's raw meat or literal poison, you'll be fine.

Hometown (Rank 1)

No matter how far away you've traveled or how long you've been gone, when you return, there's always a soft bed and a hot meal waiting for you and your allies back home. Once in a while, you might receive a letter from home, perhaps with a useful item or opportunity.

Combat

You've Done it Now! (Rank 1)

Gain +2 to all rolls if all your Blades are incapacitated.

Stealth Strike (Rank 2)

If your Blade used the talent Distracting Strike on their last turn, and you attack the same target, they cannot defend against your attack, and positional tag bonuses apply regardless of your location.

To Me! (Rank 2)

Once per combat, you strike and then call your Blade to your side, moving their turn to immediately after yours. If your Blade has the talent To You!, you may activate both of these talents at once, each declare an attack, and add your successes together for any targets you both hit. This double attack counts as this turn cycle's action for both of you.

Summon Art (Rank 7)

Instead of activating your arts on your turn, you summon them, manifesting their etheric essences in a ready state and holding onto them. After summoning an art, the art's cooldown starts ticking as normal, and you can choose to use the art at any time, including on others' turns. You may hold up to three summoned arts at a time, including duplicates of the same art.

Quick Step (Rank 3)

Requires 3 swiftness

You can move up to 4 squares per turn and easily scale climbable objects.

Fleet of Foot (Rank 5)

Requires Quick Step and 5 swiftness

You can move up to 5 squares per turn and leap across gaps with ease.

Bondsight (Rank 5)

Requires 7 attunement

You can see the flow of ether that ties Blades to Bearers. By intentionally positioning yourself between enemy partners to obstruct their bond, you give both Blade and Bearer -1 to all actions until one of them moves. You are immune to pincer attacks while this is in effect. This effect only activates if your movement is what puts you in place.

Aura Field (Rank 4)

You can tap your Blade's ether to create a shield, fully protecting yourself and anyone in up to three consecutive squares behind you from one attack. You may use this talent at any time, but you cannot take an action on your next turn when you do, and you may not use this ability again until after that turn.

Trebu-Blade (Rank 3)

Once per combat, you may roll unopposed to use a launch art on your Blade. Your Blade does not need to be broken and does not take any damage or effects from your art attack. If your Blade is launched into someone, they become the target of your art attack, and take all the damage and non-launch effects from the art you used if they fail a defense roll in addition to launch collision damage.

Cut the Cord (Rank 3)

You can stymie the flow of ether through your body to fend off illness, taking 2 damage to remove one elemental effect of your choice.

Blade Talents

Blades are people who are etheric to their core. Therefore, when a Blade has full mastery of both their own body and their bond with their Bearer, there's limitless possibilities for what they can do.

General

Ghosts of the Past (Rank 1)

Character creation only

Whatever you did in your last life, you made a great impact. Every so often, someone will recognize you and comment on your past deeds. Whether the mysteries of this Blade's past are yours or the Architect's for keeping is up to you.

Jet Boots (Rank 4)

Rather than walk, you hover slightly off the ground. This allows you to float over water and traverse any rough ground with ease. However, you'll still fall if there isn't some surface a few inches below you.

Shapeshifter (Rank 5)

While Blades' forms are ethereal and can change in minor ways, you have far more skill at manipulating your form than most. You can take on any form, humanoid, beastly, or even as an inanimate object, though you cannot significantly change your overall size. Your core will always be visible somewhere on your body, but you can hide it through mundane means.

Record Keeper (Rank 1)

Character creation only

Maybe your core is a family heirloom. Maybe it's a weapon historically used by a major government. In any case, it's never been a mystery what's going to happen to you after your Bearer dies. As a result, you've been able to keep a journal spanning many past lives.

Restless (Rank 1)

Unlike other Blades, you have no need for sleep, ether itself being enough to keep you standing.

Symbiosis (Rank 3)

More than just a part of a Titan's etheric ecosystem, you've spoken to the great beings enough to develop a relationship with them. Once you've spent enough time on a particular Titan, you can commune with them through the ether. You could ask them for guidance, or even possibly for aid; they might move a limb to open a path for you, tilt towards the Cloud Sea to let you back up, or offer other such services that only a being as massive, slow, and wise as a Titan can.

Combat

Protective Aegis (Rank 3)

You may give any amount of your HP to your Bearer at any time during your turn, and you do not pay the additional 1 HP cost to save your Bearer from unconsciousness.

Final Flicker (Rank 1)

If you do not have enough HP to restore your Bearer to consciousness, you may restore your Bearer to 1 HP at the cost of all of your remaining HP.

Essence Exchange (Rank 5)

Once per combat, you may give up any amount of your HP, converting it to special points.

To You! (Rank 2)

Once per combat, you strike and then make way for your Bearer to follow up, moving their turn to directly follow this one. If your Bearer has the talent To Me!, you may activate both of these talents at once, each declare an attack, and add your successes together for any targets you both hit. This double attack counts as this turn cycle's action for both of you.

Living Amalgam (Rank 4)

You have assimilated an unforged core into yourself, gaining the powers of the Blade sleeping within. You gain your choice of +1 radius movement per turn, +3 initiative, or +4 HP. Whether you consume this Blade's consciousness utterly, leaving only shreds of their personality behind, or allow them to live on as a part of you and share your body is up to you.

Distracting Strike (Rank 2)

Once per combat after rolling a successful attack, you strike with an attention-grabbing flash, forcing your target to face in a direction of your choosing until their next turn, regardless of other attacks inflicted on them. If your Bearer has the Bearer talent Stealth Strike, they can capitalize on your effort with their next attack.

Ghost Factory (Rank 4)

You've mastered the modulation of your etheric presence to such an extent that you can appear to be in two places at once. Once per combat, as long as you are within your radii, you can create an illusory duplicate. This duplicate stays in the same radius as you, and you can attack from either you or your illusion's position. If an enemy attacks it, they automatically miss, and the duplicate disappears. If you are attacked, defend as normal, and the duplicate disappears due to your lapse in concentration. If you go beyond your highest radius the duplicate also disappears. Outside of combat, so long as you are near your Bearer, you may summon your duplicate and act through it. You can only focus as much as normal, however, so attempting to do two different tasks at once will be challenging.

Parry (Rank 1)

If your Bearer is targeted by an attack from an enemy occupying a square in your current radius or higher, you may choose to take the blow without defending, receiving both the damage and effects from it. If you do, you are moved to the nearest square between the attacker and your Bearer, or adjacent to the attacker if they are within your first radius.

Orbital Death Beam (Rank 10)

Somehow, you've wound up etherically tapping into the controls for an ancient planetary defense system. Once per arc, so long as you have a direct view of the sky, you can call down rays of searing light to blast all enemies. Roll a basic attack, ignoring range, with an attribute of your choice. All enemies that are hit receive all negative elemental effects.

Mister Eddy (Rank 3)

Whether you more closely resemble a large animal than a human or you're just that much taller than your Bearer, they can comfortably sit on you while you walk around. In combat, you're used to fighting while your Bearer is on your back. When you two are together like this, you occupy the same square and face the same way. On your turn, instead of moving in radii around your Bearer, you may move up to six squares per turn (this distance cannot be doubled by not attacking, and does not stack with other movement bonuses). When you do, your Bearer is moved with you. Your Bearer may also move both of you six squares on their turn. Unless using an area of effect attack, enemies must choose only one of you to hit. If either of you are broken, toppled, or launched, your Bearer is forced off of you into the adjacent square farthest from the enemy. Your Bearer may mount or dismount you from an adjacent square on their turn at the cost of all their remaining movement that turn, including movement gained by being mounted.

Radius Master (Rank 5)

You take no penalty in your third radius and can act in a fourth and fifth radius at -1.

Swift Slide (Rank 4)

Requires 4 swiftness

You can move an additional radius on your turn.

Expeditionist (Rank 1)

You can move up to two squares per turn outside your maximum radius and take actions at the better of half your normal roll rounded up or a -3 penalty.

Premonitions (Rank 2)

Requires 2 attunement

Your attunement to the flow of ether sometimes grants you glimpses of the future. Once per combat, these visions enable you or your Bearer to reroll a failed attempt to avoid damage.

Forgotten Flash (Rank 3)

Lost memories from a previous Bearer sometimes briefly return to you in the heat of battle. Once per arc, you may exchange one tag on an art for any other valid tag for one use of that art.

Pair Talents

Blades and Bearers are at their best when they work as a cohesive unit.

Pair Talents require a Bearer and their Blade to acquire them at the same time but they offer unique and powerful effects for a partnership.

The Odd Couple (Rank 4)

The time you've spent together has led you to a unique and inscrutable way of interacting. Your shared mannerisms are so eccentric that you can easily be heard but not understood, seen but not comprehended, to the point where people's confusion will let you get away with nearly anything together.

Three-Core Monte (Rank 3)

Due to an ... *unscrupulous* past, the two of you have a go-to con that you have down to a science. When you perform this con in a populous area, you will attract a victim who you can extort for money, goods, or information. Do this too often in one place, however, and you may get some unwanted attention.

It's Like We Finish Each Other's... (Rank 3)

The two of you know each other's mannerisms and body language so well that you can silently communicate in a way that's almost imperceptible, let alone comprehensible, to others. You can do this so well, in fact, that you can hold entire conversations without anyone else in the room even knowing.

...Sandwiches! (Rank 2)

Requires It's Like We Finish Each Other's...

When your partner attempts to communicate with you using *It's Like We Finish Each Other's...*, you may deliberately misunderstand them. If you do, take +2 to the action you choose to believe they hinted at.

Where Were You on the Night of December 1st? (Rank 2)

If your partner is under suspicion of an illicit activity, you've already manufactured an air-tight alibi for them.

Like Siblings (Rank 1)

It's not too uncommon for the appearance of Blades to be influenced by their Bearers. This is exceptionally true for you. When the Blade's core isn't visible, people tend to assume you are twins, similar to the extent that you can convince people you are each other.

Pinky and the Blade (Rank 2)

One of you has a serious streak, the other is too silly to be taken seriously. The way your antics naturally bounce off each other has a way of swaying an audience, granting a +3 on checks made to do so as long as you cooperate.

Archetype Talents

Blade or Bearer, there's something special about you.

Archetype Talents are special talents that fundamentally define a large aspect of your being. You may only take one of these, and only at character creation or following an exceptional event. Each archetype allows you to take certain additional talents that can be bought at any time. Archetypes have major implications about how you interact with and fit into the world, so choose whether you take one wisely.

Bearer Archetype Talents

Untouched (Rank 1)

Inside every living being is a well of ether... Except for you. In you, ether knows no purchase. You may have been Untouched since birth, or maybe an overwhelming etheric event fundamentally changed you. Because ether does not bind to you, you cannot be inflicted with elemental effects, detected by etheric means, or affected by ether in any way. This also means that you have no elemental affinity yourself (you cannot use or acquire affinities or their effects) and are not affected by healing magic besides your own arts and your Blade's ability to funnel their life force into you. However, thanks to your personal etheric converter, a device that would pump a lethal amount of ether into anyone that'd be bothered by that sort of thing, you can interface with the world's energy in limited ways, most notably by bonding with Blades. If you take this archetype, your attunement is permanently reduced to 0. You fail any attunement rolls automatically, and roll without attunement in checks that call for it along with other attributes.

Many treat ether as the most important force in the universe, powering everything from magic to technology. Though you are unable to tap this otherworldly force, you've learned to use this to your advantage.

Untouched Talents

Ether Filter (Rank 5)

You have augmented your etheric converter with a filter that allows certain magical abilities to affect you. With this, you can be healed by healing arts or empowered by positive elemental effects.

Etheric Reflector (Rank 6)

Fundamentally, your etheric converter and a synthetic Blade's ether furnace are the same technology, just for moving ether in different directions. Knowing this, you equipped your converter with a reversal valve, allowing you to store one elemental effect that hit you and unleash it at a target of your choice through an attack of your own.

Negative Presence (Rank 3)

Your ether well has deteriorated to the point where, beyond being empty, it has turned into an active ether sink. Ether around you becomes destabilized and ineffective, and highly etheric beings such as Blades are instinctively repulsed by you. Blades other than your own will be pushed away one square should you move into a square adjacent to theirs.

Telethial (Rank 1)

No one is quite sure why this happens, but sometimes, before one is born, they absorb an inordinate amount of ether in the womb. It happens rarely, and there is no apparent commonality between location, environmental conditions, lineage, or even species when it does. You, and the others who have an abnormally high level of ether stored within, are Telethial. When you are knocked unconscious, or whenever you choose to give up control of your body, you transform into a Telethia, a translucent, green monster made of pure ether. While in this form, you use an art of your choice every turn regardless of cooldowns, but you cannot fully control your actions. On a successful hit, you strike your intended target for normal damage, but on a failure, the art strikes an ally of the Architect's choice with the number of successes you needed to pass the attack check. After three turns in this form, you return to your normal form, unconscious. You permanently have small, green, glowing wings on your back, though they have no weight and can easily be hidden by clothing.

The more powerful you grow, the more powerful your Telethial form becomes as well. You can only wonder if your will is enough to keep it subdued.

Telethial Talents

Drakos' Wings (Rank 3)

Your Telethial wings let you ride the ether currents, enabling you to fly. Once per combat, you may take to the air, doubling your movement speed for three turns and ignoring impassable terrain. When you fly, your wings expand significantly, becoming temporarily impossible to hide.

Soul Read (Rank 4)

Once per combat you can tap into your latent power and read your enemy's soul, enabling you to reroll a failed attack or defense. If you take this talent, your eyes turn emerald green, unnatural in hue and brightness on close inspection, distinct from even across the battlefield when you invoke your power.

Disciple's Control (Rank 5)

Cannot be taken with Endbringer's Power
You have trained day and night to gain control over the Telethia within. When you roll a near miss to land an art in Telethial form, you wrest control from the beast at the last second, forcing the attack off course where it hurts no one. If you take this talent, you can now turn the tiny wings on your back invisible with intense concentration.

Endbringer's Power (Rank 5)

Cannot be taken with Disciple's Control
Your Telethial form draws yet more strength from the land around you. Each time you attack in that form, you siphon all of the ether in a 3x3 area, turning the land barren and gray and adding 3 damage to your arts, whether they hit your desired target or not. If you take this talent, the tips of your fingers become permanently Telethial, green with yellow sparks of ether, though you could hide them with gloves.

To any onlooker, Jun and Janae were unmistakable. The metal box sitting in Jun's lap, electricity humming its gentle song through the cable looped around their waist, cast a visual symphony of blinking indicator lights, though this fell flat against the dazzling luminescence of the great wings spreading from Janae's back, almost peacock-like if not for their monstrosity. The pearlescent wings flashed and fluttered, rising and falling with Janae's slow breathing. Janae's green-dusted fingers rapped gently against their thighs as they sat in quiet concentration. They let out a breath and the wings grew, fractal tendrils of glowing amber splitting and twitching. A breath in and the wings droop, slow, yet not gentle, moreso ominous, and as this thought worked through Janae's head, their concentration broke and their great wings dematerialized, leaving only a pair of hand-length fragments floating beneath their shoulders. Janae sighed frustratedly.

"How long was that this time?" Jun chimed in. "Must've been—"

"Fifty-six seconds," Janae sighed, shaking their head in disappointment. "So close..."

"You'll hit a minute next time! Karah will be back soon anyways, so you should relax. Save that energy for all of the cleaning we've gotta do once we have supplies—"

"To clean up HER fur! How does she shed so much? She's made of ether and rocks!"

Jun laughed. "Should've thought ahead, had her take a bag of fur into town—"

"Jun." Janae leaned forward, tilting their head aside disapprovingly. "Stop that."

With a grand, uncharacteristically theatrical sigh, Jun slumped towards the ground, their chest beating the drums of protest by thudding against their ether converter. "You can't even read my mind! You don't know what I was going to say!"

"I don't need to know what you're thinking. No petty revenge allowed, Jun."

Jun mumbled something, but Janae knew what surrender sounded like. In the quiet moments that followed, Janae swished their hand idly, flicking off yellow sparks of concentrated ether. They ambled onto the breeze, almost indistinguishable against the light of the setting sun, floating towards Jun, near whom they stuttered unnaturally for a moment before fizzling out one by one. Jun doesn't notice. The twins sat in silence for a while, Janae focused on honing their control, Jun on keeping their eyes open, the flashing of the light labeled "low ether store" in their lap fighting valiantly, but fruitlessly, to keep them awake.

... Eventually, Jun awoke to a wet feeling on their cheek. "I... Karah...?"

They groggily wiped a hand across the spot in question — slobber-soaked as expected. Two laughs came in response; one mirthful, the other mischievous.

"Good morning, Jun. The sun's nearly set," the newly-returned canine Blade said. "I've brought the things you asked for. Shall we get you recharged and then to bed?"

Karah placed a paw on Jun's ether converter. The machine was silent, lights out.

"Guess so," Jun replied, sleepily placing a hand behind Karah's ears. "How was town?"

"Same as always," Karah said, "a handful of rude looks and another rejected pity discount at the store." She carefully picked up the bag of supplies in her mouth.

Janae's wings fluttered them to their feet, and Jun followed mundanely, taking care to pick up the dead weight in their lap. Another day in the uneventful life of Janae, the Telethial, and Jun, the twin they'd rendered Untouched, had come and gone. Where many would look to their unique properties to identify them, the twins saw themselves differently: siblings, as any others could be.

Blade Archetype Talents

Artificial Core (Rank 1)

In order to become a Bearer, a person needs the potential to bond with Blades. Therefore, any would-be Bearers lacking it were left completely out of luck. That was, however, until a determined ponop inventor refused to let that stop him. He created the first completely synthetic Blade, whose design was an early inspiration for yours. Rather than a core, you are powered by an ether furnace housed in your manufactured body. As an autonomous construct, you are not reliant on your Bearer's energy to keep moving, able to continue functioning even if they are knocked unconscious. When your Bearer is not in combat, you may move movement + 2 squares per turn and do not take any radius or out-of-radius penalties. However, your artificiality means you cannot share your life force to revive your Bearer. Nevertheless, whether it's because of your programming or your own feelings, your bond with your Bearer is as real as any other Blade's.

Natural Blades might be a tried-and-tested formula, but you can always improve on an old standby! You're always looking for ways to get better.

Artificial Core Talents

Pop-'n'-Swap (Rank 4)

Whenever you have downtime, you may temporarily swap your core's elemental affinity, temporarily trading access to one element's unique elemental effect and elemental mastery field skill for another. You cannot add your temporary element's shared elemental effect to an art, and instances of your normal element's shared skill work as if you had not swapped.

Extra-Efficient Processor (Rank 2)

You are capable of performing tedious, repetitive tasks such as mental math, record-keeping, or tracking with ease and are not affected by exhaustion. You are guaranteed success on such tasks so long as you know how to do them and have enough time to undertake them.

Ether Furnace Overdrive (Rank 5)

After using an art, you can immediately use another, whether or not it is off cooldown. After using this second art, it becomes unavailable for the rest of combat.

Flesh Eater (Rank 1)

Though considered taboo, there is a process for infusing humanoid cells into a Blade. Maybe you were forced into this through a cruel experiment, or maybe you chose to do it in order to save your memories after your old Bearer's passing, but either way, you became a Flesh Eater. When your Bearer is knocked unconscious, and even when they eventually die, you do not retreat to your core. As such, you have a separate dead box from your Bearer. When your Bearer is not in combat, as you do not need to etherically sustain them, you may move movement + 2 squares per turn and do not take any radius or out-of-radius penalties. However, you cannot use life force sharing to save your Bearer more than once per combat, and someday, like all living beings, the life within you will fade. You may have a longer lifespan than the average human, but you are still mortal.

Between the social stigma, the limited lifespan, and the mourning that other Blades never have to do, you have likely been dealt a rough hand. However, it's not like being a Flesh Eater doesn't come with any perks. Your existence as a being who is part humanoid, part Blade grants you access to some unique powers.

Flesh Eater Talents

Lease on Life (Rank 5)

Your living cells allow you to temporarily take on the role of Bearer. When a Bearer in your party is knocked unconscious, you may allow one of their Blades to avoid retreating into their core by acting as their Bearer. Their radii now revolve around you, and together you can perform special attacks using their special dice, which remain separate from the pool you share with your Bearer. Attacks from your temporary Blade grant them special points, but your attacks only increase your and your Bearer's pool. You may only have one temporary Blade at a time. If you are knocked unconscious, you can no longer sustain the bond, and that Blade retreats into their core.

Bond Forged in Battle (Rank 2)

As a Flesh Eater, your bond with your Bearer is made by choice, not by etheric covenant. Once per combat, you can choose to act as a different Bearer's Blade for the rest of combat. If your normal Bearer is unconscious, you contribute your special meter to your new Bearer's; otherwise, it stays with your normal Bearer.

Carry On (Rank 3)

Flesh Eaters do not lose their memories when their Bearers pass, and with enough time, even memories long forgotten may occasionally come back. Once per arc, your memories aid you, and you may ask the Architect a question. If you can justify how your experience with a previous Bearer gave you the knowledge you seek, the Architect will answer honestly.

The rain bounced off Aria's body as she hurried back towards the small village. The town doctor warned her not to go out in this storm. Even if she didn't get attacked by beasts or struck by lightning, a fairly large risk considering the high percentage of her body composed of copper, the odds of recovery were slim. Still, she tightly clutched the freshly-picked medical herbs.

"Hey! I think I got her working!" A pair of warm smiles greeted the fresh consciousness who had just awoken. One pulled a screwdriver out of the machine's forehead and extended their hand. "Name's Lewis." They pointed the tool at the figure beside them. "And this here is my Blade, Eryn."

The robot rose to her feet, ignoring the hand of the helpful human. "Autonomous Robotic Intelligent Attacker online. Acknowledging new Bearer: Lewis."

"Well, you don't have to..." Lewis paused. "Oh, what the heck. Welcome to the team, Aria."

The Blade named Eryn leapt towards Aria, almost tripping over various bits of metal littering the scrapyard, and embraced the synthetic Blade. "Welcome!"

A howl pierced through the sound of the falling rain. Aria screamed internally. If she still had a Bearer, she would be able to take them on, no problem, but unbonded as she was, they would tear her apart. The glow of the village grew closer. If she could just make it a little further...

Lewis let out a hardy laugh, face briefly emerging for their fifth ale. Despite a packed tavern, only one person was able to outpace them. Eryn, fifteenth glass in hand, scooched up next to Aria. "I know you can't eat or drink, but I still hate to see you there having no fun."

The faintest hint of curiosity crossed Aria's stoic face. "Fun?"

Eryn leapt up and beckoned Aria onto the dance floor. "Come on, I'll show ya."

The steps of the wolves grew closer far quicker than the light of the town. Aria scanned the area around her, desperate for a solution to her predicament. Listening closely, she heard something different than when she came this way the first time. The raindrops hitting the shallow pond in front of her reverberated intensely. The storm must have caused it to flood! Aria smirked. The android kicked her feet together, a small jet of fire erupting from her heels. She floated over the pond, waving back at the wolves stuck at its shore. She would make it back...

"Lewis!" Eryn screamed, tears pouring down her face. The Bearer struggled to breathe, a large sword sticking out of their chest. A glow bled off of Eryn, her body starting to break off into shards of light.

Aria fell to her knees. She couldn't lose them... not both of them... not on the same day. She desperately searched her database for a solution. Lewis was gone, but Eryn... Eryn might make it. Yes, as taboo as it was, she was desperate. She would make Eryn a Flesh Eater.

The moment Aria arrived in the village, she busted down the door to the doctor's house and shoved the herbs into his hands. "There. Save her," she demanded.

"I'll try," the doctor stammered, "but this sort of medicine is very touch-and-go, especially on *abominations*-"

"Save her," she barked again, a little louder this time.

The doctor, clearly intimidated, ran into the back room. Aria slumped down into the nearest chair. She knew that the life of a Flesh Eater was limited, that someday she really would have to say goodbye to Eryn.

Aria grinned as the doctor led a weak but very much alive Eryn out of the back room. That day wouldn't be today.

Pair Archetype Talents

Dying Devotion (Rank 1)

In a Bearer's would-be final moments, their Blade can, if they act fast enough, split their core with their Bearer to save their life. It is a process that requires a high degree of precision, but when successful, the Bearer lives on, sharing their Blade's life force forever. This is exactly what happened to the two of you. You now share one pool of HP, the sum of your individual maximums. Any damage dealt to one of you is now dealt to both of you. Therefore, when the Bearer among you dies, the Blade's core is shattered, gone with their partner.

Bearer, you are for all intents and purposes now part Blade, allowing you to purchase the following Blade-only talents:

- Ghost Factory
- Living Amalgam
- Premonitions
- Forgotten Flash

Blade, your eternal bond with your Bearer allows you to purchase the following Bearer-only talents:

- Summon Art
- Bondsight
- Bond Sever
- Cut the Cord

Body, Core, and Soul (Rank 1)

The bond you share transcends ties of ether, lattices of crystal, and even the barriers of flesh and identity, so deep that your partner is as much yourself as you are. So complete is your trust in each other that, so long as your affinity is not negative, you can break down the walls of your individual selves and become one, a being neither Bearer nor Blade but simply *you*. To take a rolled action in this form, both players must write down their intended act without discussing them and reveal them at the same time. If the two courses of action cannot reasonably reconcile or co-occur, you lose your synchronization and are forced out of merged form and take -1 to your affinity. If your action is mutual, you perform it using the better of your relevant attributes and bonuses (not including your affinity bonus). If either player writes down their intent to separate, the fusion ends that turn without an affinity penalty. For each action performed successfully in this merged state, you gain a +1 to future merged actions up to a maximum of +3. Merging may only be performed once per combat (or with a length of recovery at the Architect's discretion). If you merge in combat, you use the Bearer's movement properties, and must start and end your merge with the Blade in their first radius. Either partner may initiate a merge as their action, though it must be mutual. Use the non-initiating partner's turn as your merged-form turn, returning to your normal turn order positions when you separate. Following a reconciliation burst, you may immediately fuse, merging in the aftermath of the special attack. If you do, take your first merged turn on the next turn available to you and your partner.

Body, Core, and Soul Talents

Sword Cross (Rank 4)

In your merged state, you are more than the sum of your parts. Once you have reached a +3 merge bonus, you may draw both of your etheric weapons and execute the special art "Sword Cross," which has the tags Potency +1, Line Attack, Perfect Topple (targets are toppled even if they are not broken or dodge this art attack), Range +∞, and Precise Attack. Performing this art ends your merge without an affinity penalty.

Resynchronize (Rank 4)

The first time you fail to agree on an action during a merge, instead of being forced out of your merge and taking an affinity penalty, you may choose to either stay merged and take no action that turn or unmerge without taking an affinity penalty.

Explosive Emotion (Rank 3)

By further strengthening your bond, you have learned to channel the excess ether energy lost in merging. When you initiate a merge, you unleash a wave of ether, dealing damage equal to your current affinity bonus to all enemies within the 3x3 square centered on you.

Chapter 7: The World of Arlest

Although Arlest is mostly composed of empty seas, the Titans' backs hold an incredibly large number of diverse civilizations and species. It is said that to visit every land in Arlest, in addition to an incredible team of navigators, one would need to live to nearly a Titan's own lifespan.

You may be under the impression that you are already intimately familiar with Arlest, basing your knowledge off of similar worlds you may or may not know well. However, you will find that there are some key differences between the world in your imagination and the one outlined here, even if they are alike. That being said, these Titans, these peoples, and even the entirety of this Cloud Sea are mere suggestions. Your Architect is the creator of *your* Arlest, and may choose to change some (or even all) aspects of it.

Titans of Arlest

Outlined here are some Titans, with descriptions of their forms and the societies that live on or in them, as well as some additional pieces of information about the world. These are nowhere near all of the Titans that roam the Cloud Sea, of course, but you may find any one of them to be an excellent place to start an adventure.

Gentarum

Gentarum is technically not a Titan, but a number of smaller Titans all holding up a man-made floating city. Although the actual livable area of this city is much smaller than what is afforded to most societies on larger Titans, it is extremely densely populated, housing a people numbering in the millions. A massive ship as much as it is a city, Gentarum can be steered around freely, although it tends to stick to a set path around the World Tree so travelers are able to find it easily.

The city serves as one of the largest economic hubs in the world, and goods from all over can be bought and sold there. Fittingly, Gentarum is ruled by a council of its most successful merchants, but the council's corruption runs deep, with laws being crafted to benefit only the richest. Despite the rules, weapons and other dangerous goods can be traded for in any number of the city's darkest alleys, so long as one knows where to look. Thus, quality of life in Gentarum can vary wildly. Those with coin to spare find the finest of lodgings and food available with an unmatched degree of convenience, the rest left to simply fight for whatever scraps remain. The political landscape is tense, with many calling for change, but those who profit in Gentarum are very invested in maintaining its status quo *at all costs*.

Morgot

Morgot is one of the largest Titans in existence. Its long, giraffe-like body is almost completely covered in grasslands. The inhabitants have access to a large amount of farmable land, making it largely agricultural. Although humans and

ponop alike reside on Morgot, they are far outnumbered by the morgotti, humanoid people with cat-like ears, light fur, and claws.

The biggest threat to the people of Morgot was once the large beasts that roam the land, but the Empire of Mordania turned its eyes towards the grassy Titan's plentiful natural resources, with its military arm soon following. With little defense to speak of, the people of Morgot were unable to fight back against the sudden invasion, and have been forced to live under the thumb of the occupying Empire and its exploitative ideals for years.

Raya

The whale Titan Raya resides below the Cloud Sea, making living on the Titan's back impossible, which is why its inhabitants live within it. So long as one avoids the areas with high levels of stomach acid, Raya's innards are surprisingly habitable, if rather uncomfortable. The Titan only surfaces to eat, however, so arrivals and departures can be challenging. It's much more common to find new arrivals in Raya's mouth than in the proper ports of entry carved into the stone hide of the beast.

Sapient species are not the only ones who take advantage of Raya's habitability. Attacks by neighboring monsters are a common problem for all of the whale's towns and cities. Some, like the Frontguard Village, arm themselves, creating barricades and organizing guard troops to ensure the inhabitants don't get attacked. Others, like the capital city of Aym Safon, build their city structures vertically, making it all but impossible for beasts to reach them.

Despite the difficulty of entering the cloudlogged Titan and the danger that can be found in its less-inhabited areas, Raya is not to be missed by the dedicated Titan tourist. The breathtaking bioluminescent flora that grows in these odd conditions are worth trekking to find, and inhabited areas are surprisingly peaceful and relaxed. However, mounting political tensions with Mordania cast the shadow of impending war over Raya's many inhabitants.

Mordania

The bipedal humanoid Mordania looms over most other Titans, cutting an intimidating silhouette from even across the horizon. The capital of the Empire that shares its Titan's name is perched precariously atop the giant's shoulder, from which hang the remnants of its long-severed arm. Mordania is dying; the wounds it has taken in the Empire's battles, the overharvesting of its limited resources, and the Empire's ecologically devastating large-scale weapons manufacturing have seen to that. What little land is habitable at all is desolate, difficult to navigate, faced with extreme heat and water shortages, and plagued by social trouble, making life for the Empire's average inhabitant difficult.

The ruling class of Mordania, meanwhile, has fought war after war to enrich themselves at the expense of every other denizen of Arlest, their own citizens included. The populace is deeply divided, some willing to accept these atrocities for

nationalist pride or a misguided belief that someday they will share in the Empire's spoils, but just as many one push away from rising up against the Imperial banner.

It is rumored that the rulers of Mordania's empire intend to abandon their dying Titan by overtaking another one... unless they fall in the brewing civil war first.

Leftria

Leftria is the collective name of a group of symbiotically linked jellyfish-like Titans that are theorized to share a single mind. The tops of the Titans and their linking tendrils reside above the surface of the Cloud Sea, allowing them to be easily traversed on foot. This results in a archipelago-like landmass, highly unique in a sea of continental Titans.

The resources on Leftria aren't plentiful, but they're more than enough to support the tiny villages that reside there. Its lack of any real tactical value or unique specialty goods means Leftria is largely ignored by bigger nations, making life there incredibly peaceful, save for the occasional monster attack. While Leftria's elderly treasure peace, the young often grow tired of the quiet, and many who grow up there leave for adventure. Should they return at journey's end, of course, they will find open beds and warm welcomes.

Idnol

The draconic Titan of Idnol flies high above the Cloud Sea, and as a result, only aerial Titans and machines can reach its surface. This natural barrier means the people of Idnol are largely safe from attack, but rather than use it to military advantage, they use it to maintain a permanent neutrality in all inter-Titan conflicts. As the Cloud Sea's self-appointed conflict arbiter, Idnol takes in refugees from all over the world, giving the land a population as diverse as Gentarum, but many Idnoline-born hold attitudes as isolating as their military policy.

The ruler of the Idnoline theocracy is known as the Praetor, and they are believed to be personally appointed by the Architect themselves. Although this is touted as a method on which no mortal man has influence, there will always be politicking where power is to be had. The deals, betrayals, and even assassinations that lead to the current leader, however, are unknown to the general public, if frequently speculated on. Indeed, the rumors surrounding the Praetor are nigh on endless. Many believe that the Praetor uses Idnol's refugees for highly unethical experiments, and many more espouse that they use the shield of an alleged neutrality to secretly manipulate wars for their advantage. Taken together, it is easy to see the Architect's so-called chosen ruler in a far more sinister light than they would like.

Bengu

Bengu is a bit of an odd case for an inhabited Titan, as Bengu is dead, and has been for hundreds of years. Once upon a time, many lived on the back of the giant turtle. Following its death, the remaining inhabitants crawled into its insides and

used stolen Ronat technology to craft an etheric control device to replace the Titan's brain. This device was embedded inside a Blade, which is passed down from each ruling family monarch to their eldest child with potential.

As Bengu is no longer able to feed the environment with its ether, everything inside is slowly dying, and the environment grows colder and colder. Out of a sense of sheer stubbornness, the royal family refuses to ask for aid from other Titans, and Bengu rarely surfaces. The people of Bengu worry about a slow death as their resources dwindle generation after generation.

Ronat

The large, serpent-like Ronat began its life as a particularly violent Titan, attacking and consuming other Titans to feed itself. In ages past, an ancient ruling monarch was able to weave lines of ether around it, rendering it docile and bringing peace to the country. Since then, the Titan has remained contained, and its plentiful resources have kept its inhabitants comfortably fed and housed.

Ronat's womb is particularly fertile, and the serpent produces an exceptionally high number of Blade cores each year. In fact, it is said that Ronat sees ten times more new Blades than the average Titan. Naturally, Bearers are an extremely frequent sight throughout Ronat's cities. The density of capable partners plus the sheer strength of the Titan itself deters other nations from attacking, so those who desire Ronat's resources are forced to barter rather than fight.

The Waning Warriors

On the far side of the Cloud Sea, two Titans stand locked in a timeless battle. Vanishingly little is known about this humanoid pair, but the few travelers who have made the journey and returned to speak of it all agree on one thing: these Titans are dead, towering in their endless stalemate, one's six-mile sword plunged into the other's chest and its severed arm laying lifeless in the sea as perhaps the only true island in all Arlest.

The handful of adventurers who've disembarked on the sword-struck Titan saw mundane societies not unlike ones in familiar waters. However, its opponent remains shrouded in mystery. An entirely mechanical Titan, accounts claim, despite the obvious impossibility of such a feat. Who could have created this simulacrum, and what manner of being, if any, might call it home?

Indeed, the Waning Warriors, as many have come to call them, inspire endless questions in all who hear their story. What caused these giants to battle? What will happen to their corpses in the eons to come? Do the peoples of the mechanical Titan, if they even exist, live in harmony with their neighbors, or does the Titanic duel that preceded them continue even now in the form of war? Is the story of these twin Titans more than a myth? And what became of the other titanic weapon? Someday these questions may be answered, but for now, the truth is simply too far away.

Creating Titans

The world of Arlest contains many Titans beyond the ones described in this section of the book, and your journeys may take you just about anywhere. There are a couple ways Titans may be added to the game. For one, you might create Titans as a part of your character's background. If you choose to do this, the Architect must approve of the details of these Titans. A good Architect will work together with you when they have concerns, ensuring your Titan is good for both the Architect's world and your story. You may do this at any time, not just during character creation. The other way to add Titans is for the Architect to add them on their own. The Architect may decide to craft all the details themselves or offer to allow the players to define aspects of these Titans depending on their storytelling style. Both of these methods offer advantages and should be considered when planning a game.

You may find the following questions helpful when creating Titans. They will help you flesh out these lands and societies as you create them. If you are creating Titans collaboratively, it may be fun for all players and the Architect to take turns picking questions to answer. While there are no real limitations to creating Titans beyond what the Architect deems necessary, a Titan is most fleshed-out when the answers to these questions have strong influence over each other.

What is the Titan's shape? Titans come in many forms, usually shaped like animals or mythological creatures. The answer to this question should also determine how, or if, the Titan traverses the Cloud Sea, how large the Titan is, and whether the Titan resides above, below, or amid the clouds.

How many people live here? Does this Titan house millions, or is there only one small village on its back? Maybe no one lives here, and the Titan is either completely uninhabitable or home to only animals. This question should also determine *why* the population is what it is. Is this Titan undiscovered? Does it have plentiful resources that allow for a huge population? Or was it home to many people until some calamity hit?

Who lives here? Arlest isn't just populated by humans. It isn't just populated by Blades, morgotti, or ponop either. The world is full of all sorts of sapient (and non-sapient) life! Maybe this Titan is populated by talking cats and floating squids with bulging brains. If your answer to the previous question is zero and the Titan was previously undiscovered, you may skip this question. If it's zero due to a cataclysmic event, however, who used to live here?

What is the ecosystem like? Animals, plant life, and climate. The etheric flow of a Titan heavily influences the weather, temperature, and topography on top of and within it, and this, in turn, impacts what life will thrive (if any).

What is the population's governmental structure? Almost all populated Titans' governments function entirely independently of each other. As such, there are a large variety of ruling structures across the Cloud Sea. Monarchies, democracies, anarchies, authoritarian states — all can be found, and all with varying levels of

success. Some places may be practically utopias, others dens of horrid corruption. It is also possible that the people of this Titan are not united, and multiple governments exist on it. If the population of this Titan is zero due to a cataclysmic event, what used to be the governmental structure?

How are Blades treated? Although some Titans produce more cores than others, Blades exist within every Titan. As they contain a great deal of power, they are integral to almost every society. They may be treated exclusively as living weapons to be controlled, or rightfully dealt with as living people, afforded as many rights as anyone else. Maybe the people of your Titan consider Blades to be just too dangerous and store cores in safehouses, never to be forged. Perhaps the number of Blades is just too low for it to be reasonable to test people for potential, making Blades an extremely rare sight. As all players are either Bearers or Blades themselves, this is a very important question to answer.

What is this Titan known for? Maybe there are beautiful gems that can only be mined within this Titan, or maybe the large waterfalls decorating the landscape are one of the most stunning sights on the Cloud Sea. Unless a Titan is completely undiscovered, there is *something* it is known for, even if only in small circles or to the inhabitants of Titans that pass nearby.

What dangers are facing this Titan? Resources could be running thin. Civil war could be on the horizon. The Titan could be sick. There are numerous perils facing the people of Arlest, and almost no Titan is free of them. You may choose to answer this question with “none,” but, if you are creating many Titans, be careful not to do this too often. If you are the Architect and you are collaboratively creating Titans, you may or may not want to answer this question yourself and keep it secret.

Above the World Tree

Although some claim to have successfully climbed the World Tree, such claims are impossible to verify. It is a perilous journey, and anyone who was confirmed to have attempted the feat never returned. There are many contradictory rumors of what lies above, some of which have been listed below. In the end, only the Architect knows for sure, and they may either pick one of these rumors or make up a completely different answer to this mystery.

Paradise: bountiful fields with unlimited resources, perfect weather all the time, and lost technology that could completely automate away all of life’s hardships. It could be that the Architect built this place as a reward for anyone that could reach it, that people used to live here but left for some reason, or that people still live here and are hoarding this land for themselves. Ultimately, only the Architect knows why paradise lies there.

Space Station: full of long-lost technology, the World Tree holds what remains of the final stand humanity made against a forgotten world-ending threat. Although once fit for human life, it long ago grew barren, with the only useful resource

being the unknown technologies that could be retrieved if only someone could reach them. Some rumors even state that the Architect himself still resides up there, clinging to life after countless years.

Life's Cradle: all life started from here, and has since migrated down to the Cloud Sea. There isn't much left to see up there now, but there are still many scientific questions that could be answered by proving this rumor true.

Branches: the World Tree is... just a tree. But left alone for all these years, what could possibly call it home? What strange life has developed clinging to the boughs above the sky?

Beneath the Cloud Sea

Getting below the Cloud Sea is a lot easier than climbing the World Tree. Whether through a salvaging accident or a venture too close to the Great Void, countless lives have been lost to its foggy depths. Only one thing is certain: no one has ever returned from far below. No Titan or technology can reach its bottom and return a diver to tell the tale. Of course, this hasn't stopped speculation, but, much like with the top of the World Tree, whether any of these rumors hold water – or, rather, hold cloud – is anyone's guess. Still, the fact that salvagers keep finding things proves there must be *something* down there.

Ancient Ruins: before the era of Titans, people lived comfortably on a surface that no living person has ever seen. There may be priceless technologies down there, or perhaps the world above is more advanced than that one ever became.

Living Societies: the surface of the planet, despite a complete lack of sun, is completely habitable. Life may be better or worse down there than on the backs of Titans, but much like the people above lack the technology to reach the land, those from below lack the technology to leave solid ground. These rumors tend to be popular with those close to people who have been lost at sea, as the thought that their loved ones may be alive somewhere is a happy one.

Dimensional Tear: this rumor claims that there is a rip in the universe below the sea. Things randomly float in and out, but its destination changes by the second, with no guarantee of ever seeing Arlest again. Despite being an inarguably fantastical theory, it would be a good explanation for some of the weirder things salvagers have found, and thus it has found many feverish believers.

Titan Corpses: the most mundane, if incomplete, theory is that the ocean floor is littered with corpses of fallen Titans and the nations they once housed. There is reason to believe this, after all, as dead titans inevitably fall, so there must be many corpses in the cloudy depths. But to say that it is only corpses does not explain the things pulled from beneath the clouds. It cannot explain the technology bearing crests of empires that never were, nor the crafts made with flawless precision that no one can emulate or even explain. Perhaps this is only part of the truth.

Chapter 8: The Architect

It is common knowledge that the Architect created the world and guided the beginning of all life. However, scholars disagree on how far that guidance goes. Some think that once the Architect set the world in motion, they disappeared completely. Others think their hand still guides every action taken in Arlest. Ultimately, however, both factions agree on the importance of the Architect's touch.

Just as the Architect of Arlest sets the world ticking and the tides turning, the Architect in *Blades of Ether* is the initiating and driving force of the players' adventure. This chapter contains advice and instruction for the Architect of your game. If you're not the Architect, you may wish to skip the next two chapters – sometimes, what's behind the curtain is best left a mystery.

Architect's Principles

As the Architect, your role is essential to delivering a complete *Blades of Ether* experience. These principles are a set of guidelines to keep in mind as you play. They will help you start off strong towards playing the game with the right tone and in a way that's fun and interesting.

Be a Fan of the Characters. Be excited for the things your players do – their successes, their failures, their trials and tribulations. Push them into growth, but don't push them into suffering. Be lenient on your calls if it means letting them shine, let them have defining moments of character and creativity, and bend the rules a little if someone is genuinely excited about something.

Encourage Quiet Moments. Your characters aren't just defined by their actions in combat or tense political meetings. They have heart-to-hearts over food, play games together, and banter with each other in a dangerous spot. This is where relationships grow from, and they will make your grand combat encounters even grander.

Render the World in Vivid Color. The world that surrounds you is beautiful and dangerous in equal measure, so represent both sides of it at once. The beauty of an impossible environment as seen from a mountaintop, the strangeness of the rain in an alien landscape, and the gentle glow of the trees at nightfall; the danger of a rampaging creature at the top of the food chain, the horror of walking along fragile cliff faces, and the desolace of the burned tree that blocks the way; all of these, inseparable, are your Arlest.

Embrace Whimsy. If the world was entirely serious, then it wouldn't be accurate. Reality is goofy and silly and strange! Let players make joke characters, allow people to make decisions for goofy reasons, and let the characters have fun with the environment. Of course, you also have to know when to lock it down and be serious for the sake of tone and story.

Let the Players Lead the Charge. This is not a game about the world happening to the players. The characters make decisions, drive themselves, and impact the world. At small scale, this means that the game is about *them* first and foremost. NPCs are great, but the player characters are the ones this game is for and about, and their decisions should guide the story more than anything else. At large scale, have the players decide what their characters do at the top of every session. There's nothing wrong with sessions where players react to a scenario you've created, and, especially early on, these can be quite good, but make sure to let the characters take the lead and make decisions about where to go and what to do next. Often, the story can just come from them throwing themselves into the world without thinking first.

Embrace Unexpected Outcomes and Worst-Case Scenarios. Often, the obvious choice isn't the interesting one. What might seem like a bad route or a terrible decision can lead the story in a new direction or show a character in a light you wouldn't otherwise see. Things can always get worse, failure is always an option, and the heroes don't always win the day. You can always build up from rock-bottom, after all. That said...

Nothing Needs To Be Permanent. You don't need every ruling to be ironclad, nor every decision to be harsh. Time is malleable and the backspace key exists. If a story beat doesn't land, rewrite it. If the result of an action isn't fun, then ignore it. If something isn't satisfying, walk it back. It's more important that the story is interesting and the game is fun than it is for you to get it in one go.

Let Them Be Incredible. The players are powerful. This doesn't mean they're invincible, far from it, but when someone has an idea that's slightly outside of the realm of reason, bend the rules a little bit towards them. Give them space to be dramatic, to describe things lavishly, or to get excited about a wild idea.

Play to Find Out What Happens. Don't decide every event in advance. The players will impact the world, story beats will change, and your ideas will shift as you go. You never know what your players will do, and you may wind up having to rewrite everything. Leave it to fate, see what happens as you go, and roll with the punches as they come. Be excited for your story to unfold!

Rolling, Failure, and Consequences

One of your more important jobs as an Architect is to turn the numbers on the dice into outcomes. While this may seem like a minor task, there are layers of complexity underlying any possible interpretation of a roll.

Exploring Interesting Success

When the players roll and succeed, **they perform the action they described, with no unintended negative consequences.** If the players attempt to attack an enemy, and they roll *exceptionally* well, don't have the player accidentally deal a fatal blow. That's not success, but complete and utter failure, punishing them for rolling too well.

Success means that the player succeeds at their action, but it does not make that action good. It can have limited impact, make things worse in the long run, or just be a terrible idea executed perfectly. Think through the consequences of their action as honestly as you can. Err on the side of kindness, because they *did* roll well, but if they roll well to detonate a bomb that they are holding, they can't be shocked when they blow up.

Creating Interesting Failure

When someone rolls, something will always happen as a result, *especially* on a failure. The purpose of rolling is to determine where the story goes next, and "nothing happens as a result" isn't a direction, it's a brick wall in the path. If you give genuine consequences for failure, it can be one of your best assets. Good failure can make your villains feel unstoppable when they catch your sniper's bullet out of the air, make a mystery feel complex when their lead suspect turns up dead, and make your fight feel that much more dangerous when the forest around you bursts into flames. Just think through the consequences of their actions as best as you can, being honest to the story that is being told, and it will push things forwards.

Take note that it says "the consequences of their actions." This means that when a player fails, their actions still happen. The player's actions do not fail out of incompetence. A highly trained hero fighting to save the world probably won't die by accidentally tripping and falling on their sword. The player characters are at least competent as people, and at best they're the best in the world. The players fail because they miscalculate, take bad risks, underestimate their opponent, or lack a piece of information. The player didn't miss their shot because they're simply terrible at firing their bow. They missed because their opponent was faster than they expected, or because a sudden storm blew their arrow out of position. This turns failure from simply "your character messed up" into a chance to give them new information, show the threat that an opponent presents, complicate the situation in an interesting way, or demonstrate the consequences of acting on a terrible plan. Of course, if a character is inexperienced but eager, it may fit for them to trip and fall on their weapon. Nothing is set in stone and everything is malleable.

Using Near Hits and Near Misses

On a near hit, when a player garners only one net success, the action succeeds, but there is a consequence or complication as a result. The consequence could be an unforeseen drawback of success, their underestimating the difficulty of the task and pushing themselves too far, or just simply their enemy responding to their move in kind. Near hits are generally supposed to be net neutral, a good thing with a side effect. The effect doesn't negate the good thing, and the good thing doesn't negate the effect.

On a near miss, when a player meets but does not beat the check, the action fails, but results in some sort of positive effect. This could be as a result of the failure itself, incidental, or just semi-related. Near misses are generally supposed to be slightly positive. The action may not have succeeded, but at least something

good happened: the player's new position will let them land their next strike more easily, the time spent on the task teaches them something invaluable, or they manage to escape the danger they created unscathed.

Near hits and near misses are powerful tools in your belt when they come up. A near miss can be used to give the players intel they otherwise wouldn't get, and a near hit can make a villain's strength seem superhuman when they manage to counterattack your party's deadliest blow. Use them to flavor the narrative the way you want it to feel and make actions worth taking.

A near hit or near miss can even be an opportunity to pass the spotlight. The consequence of an action doesn't have to happen to the person rolling. For example, if a player attempts to block an enemy's blow and rolls a near hit, they could push the attacker forwards with their shield, forcing the enemy out of the line of sight of another player who was perched with an arrow nocked in their bow ready to fire. All it takes to move the spotlight is simply asking "What do you do?"

A benefit or complication does not preclude the result of the roll, but it can mitigate it. If a player succeeds at striking the enemy, the complication cannot be that it doesn't hurt, but it can be that their blow lands against their armor, damaging their weapon. If they fail to strike the enemy, the advantage can't be that they actually do hit them, but it can be that they manage to dodge out of the way of the forthcoming counterattack.

On Bonds and Affinity

If you're unsure when a bond has changed or if an affinity should be increased or decreased, the best advice is to simply follow your heart. The reality is that there are no hard and fast rules for when affinity increases and decreases. Just simply when it feels right and makes narrative sense.

Listen when characters interact, and reward interesting conversations as you see fit. Not every bond change needs to be associated with a massive upheaval. Sometimes it can be a small but meaningful change in how you see the other person. Those are just as meaningful as massive world-changing gestures. They're the foundation upon which a relationship is built, and should change affinity accordingly.

When in doubt, listen to your players. If you are unsure, then the most important tool you have is simply asking "do you think it's changed?" They'll know their characters better than you. If you don't immediately see it, then let them make a case for why their bond changed or affinity increased. If they have a solid case, then give it to them. And if you still don't fully agree, maybe err on their side. BP is how they grow, and growth is fun, after all.

As long as you're listening to conversations, remembering the mechanic when appropriate, and being generous when the outcome's in doubt, then there's no need to worry.

On Non-Player Characters

Creating Architect-controlled “non-player” characters, or NPCs, is extremely fun, but when making NPCs, it’s all too easy to focus on them too much. Of course, you should make them feel like real people with flaws, histories, and quirks. Fleshing out a character is how you make them feel real, and making the world feel real is the Architect’s job, but the NPCs are not the focus of the game, the *players* are. So while NPCs can and should be interesting, they shouldn’t shine so brightly that the players feel like they’re irrelevant in their light. **NPCs do not exist to be the story, they exist to be the world the story is set in.**

To this end, make characters who represent the aspects of factions, settings, and organizations. Letting the players see a faction in its entirety is simply not possible. You can’t have the players meet every single person under a banner. Rather, create individual members that represent each aspect of a group. The grand general of the Empire represents their military might and their dangerous destructive power, while the merchant represents their capitalist tendencies, subtler and more dangerous than the weapons ever could be. The revolution’s historian represents its dedication to a past wiped out by centuries of war, while the hot-headed new recruit represents the unquestioning idealistic desire for vengeance its fighters have. The kind old woman represents the love and kindness of the people in the village, while the scared man represents their fear of being pulled into the world’s troubles and the lengths they’ll go to stay isolated. The good and the bad, the dangerous and the more dangerous, the expected and unexpected, every piece of the puzzle is easy to represent in this manner.

There’s a very thin line to tread when making new NPCs. Of course you’ll want to create new characters, but having too many characters to juggle may make it difficult for the players to remember them all. Don’t be afraid to have bit part characters fade into the background or stay two dimensional, and don’t feel obligated to use every NPC you create. Some characters are fine just left in your notes. Also, when it makes sense, reuse rather than create anew. People belong to more than one community, after all. The hotshot revolutionary lives in that small village, and can show your players different things in each area. This is effective storytelling *and* it fleshes out your characters!

Creating Encounters

When the time to fight comes, you will need to be prepared. Balancing encounters can be tricky. While you may have some general ideas of where or with who the party will pick fights or be attacked, you can never know for sure. Because of this, it is recommended that you plan flexibly, and keep extra maps and enemies at the ready.

Creating Maps

The combat in *Blades of Ether* relies on two things coming together in order to really work: the actions available to the players, and the arenas they fight in. As this

is the case, flat, empty, grass fields will grow dull quickly. If you have ever played any tactics games, think of your favorite levels. They have mountains, rivers, or forests, and these can do a lot to keep the maps exciting.

When creating a map, think of what obstacles might belong there. A grassland may have a river that's uncrossable on foot unless a path is created. A forest may have trees that can be hidden behind and fallen logs that need to be jumped over. A city may have tall buildings with one or two entrances. Make sure to have your enemies interact with these obstacles as well. This will both give your players examples on how they can use them and give encounters depth.

Obstacles are not the only thing that should go on your maps. Make sure to also leave tiles the players can use to their advantage. A pile of dried leaves may turn into a cunning trap when placed near someone with fire affinity. A rickety bridge can be cut as an enemy is crossing it. A dumpster in an alley could make for an excellent hiding place. Of course, what kind of items are available should depend on the environment the map depicts.

No matter how well you think on your feet, you will not be able to create an entire map on the fly. You can prepare maps for major areas of your world, but your players will always get into a fight somewhere you didn't expect eventually. For this reason, it is recommended you keep a few extra maps on hand. You don't necessarily need a map of the capital city. A generic "city" map will usually serve you just fine. Furthermore, you can get a lot out of one map if you reuse it. Placing characters at different starting points on the same map will make for very different encounters!

Creating Enemies

You've made your maps and filled them with all sorts of interesting squares, but of course, without enemies, you'll have nothing to do with them. Thus, you'll need combatants to put on them. Combat NPCs can be described with the following information:

Name: the name of the enemy. Many of the enemies you create will likely be unnamed generic people or beasts. These could simply be called "Guild Blade #1" or "Giant Snake."

Role: there are three options here: Bearer, Blade, or other. Other refers to either a solo combatant or a non-sapient being.

Attacks: as a reminder, NPCs never roll. As such, NPCs' attack and defense values are *results*, not dice pools. When balancing these numbers, remember that a success has a one in three chance of occurring per die. Thus, to create an enemy roughly as strong as your players, their normal attack should be roughly one-third of your player's most-used attributes. Additional spaces are provided for "advantaged" and "disadvantaged" attack values, to be used when circumstances call for them. The disadvantaged and advantaged attacks should

be close in number to the normal attack, and can even be the same, especially for enemies meant for lower-level players.

Defenses: these work similarly to attacks, with a normal defense, a disadvantaged defense, and an advantaged defense. The rules on balancing these are likewise. Remember to consider your intended outcome when picking these numbers – should the players be hitting or missing more often? Note that a defense of 0 (requiring one success to beat) is perfectly acceptable, and will likely be necessary early into a campaign.

Movement: how far this enemy can move in a turn. This functions the same way as it does for player characters.

Initiative: the enemy's initiative value. Like before, this is a result, not a dice pool. Unlike the balancing act of attacks and defenses, though, you have a lot of flexibility to make very fast and very slow enemies.

HP: how much health this combatant has. Given that players will typically deal only 1-2 damage per successful attack, and a chain of special attacks will deal around the same amount of damage as was dealt while charging it, set this value to determine the length of the encounter you have in mind.

Elemental Affinity: which element(s) this enemy has access to. All Bearers and Blades must have at least one of these, but others may have none. That being said, many beasts have a natural elemental affinity.

Best Attributes: list one or two of the 12 attributes here. Although this has no mechanical effect, it should serve as a guide for how this enemy will act both in and out of combat.

Art Tags: any tags that will be on enemy attacks. Enemies don't need to have specific arts like players do, but you may decide to put some effects on their attacks every few turns, as if the enemy uses a generic art. For powerful enemies, you may even consider putting impossible combinations together, such as break and topple on the same art, instantly toppling anyone hit.

Special Abilities: any special action an enemy may take. These work like combat talents do for players. You may give enemies existing talents or make up your own. There are some examples of special abilities in [chapter 9](#).

Notes: anything you want to note down about this enemy. For NPCs, this would be a good place for a quick biography. For animals, it could just be a note about how they tend to act.

Tide-force tip: NPCs do not have arts in the same way players do, so while the cooldown-freezing effect of the water elemental effect Arts Seal doesn't apply, the art tag sealing effect does. NPCs can use the bravery shared effect Invigorating Steam to grant themselves or an ally one advantaged attack or defense.

To describe your enemies, you can use this card, printable from the [back of the book](#):

Name		Role	M	I
Attacks	Defenses	HP		
Affinities		Attributes		
Notes		Art tags		
		Special abilities		

There will likely be two kinds of enemy cards you create: NPCs and generic enemies. NPC cards are self-explanatory, describing the characters you've created as part of the world. You will want to make a card for every major NPC in the game, whether or not they are to be fought. Sometimes, characters you make up on the spot often become major NPCs, leaving you unprepared. If this happens, you can either try to improvise their card, or, if you struggle with this, give them a generic NPC card from the example list and refine it between sessions.

Generic enemies will not describe specific characters. Instead, they are meant to detail indistinct beings and nameless people. You never know for certain what kind of scuffles your players will get themselves into, but with a stock of generic enemy cards, you'll be prepared to create an encounter out of anything.

For balancing enemies relative to your players' attributes, refer to this table:

Player Attributes and Dice Pool Results												
Attribute Strength	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Average successes	0.33	0.67	1.00	1.33	1.67	2.00	2.33	2.67	3.00	3.33	3.67	4.00
Check often lost	1	1	2	2	2	3	3	3	4	4	4	5
Check often met	0	0	1	1	1	2	2	2	3	3	3	4
Check often beaten	0	0	0	1	1	1	2	2	2	3	3	3

Controlling Combat

You've got your map, you've got your enemies, and you're ready to let your players take on the challenge you've prepared for them. An important thing to keep in mind while running combat is that your goal should not be to beat the players, but

to provide them with a fun experience. You should not necessarily make the moves that would be most optimal for the enemies to take. Instead, you should consider what the enemy would do, and maybe occasionally even take a bad move if it would be too punishing to act more wisely. Walking this tightrope can be challenging, and the exact point where you need to ease up will be different for every group. Be open to learning and adjusting your play as you go.

An enemy's turn should be simpler than a player's. Their movesets are much more limited, and while enemies should engage with objects around the battlefield to their advantage, it is important not to use all of them. Doing this will encourage players to fight more creatively without using up all of their tools. Other than that, most of what an enemy will be doing on a given turn is either just attacking, running away, or taking a narratively appropriate creative action.

An important aspect of controlling enemies is knowing when they should use advantaged or disadvantaged attack and defense. For the most part, your choice of number should follow the fiction: did the enemy walk up to a player and swing a sword? Normal attack. Was the enemy caught off guard by a clever maneuver? Disadvantaged defense. Is the enemy channeling all of their anger into a powerful swing? Advantaged attack. However, these are not rigid definitions, and should not be treated as such. For example, if combat is starting to go on long and the players and enemies are stalling out, you may want to start using more disadvantaged defenses.

Remember that players cannot see your enemy cards. If you need to make an encounter last longer or end it early, you can tweak the enemy stats behind the scenes. However, do this too frequently and the players will catch on, which could make combat feel hollow. Do this sparingly, and let the players fail sometimes. Losing a battle in this system does not kill your players automatically and can lead to interesting situations.

As a final note, there may be battles where some NPCs are aligned with the party. In this case, you can treat the NPCs the same way you treat enemies. This will involve setting static numbers up against static numbers rather than any rolls occurring, but if you feel the scenario calls for it, you may decide the outcome of certain NPC vs. NPC actions with a simple coin flip.

Modifying The Game

One of the advantages of tabletop roleplaying games is that their rules are rules in the purest sense: a self-imposed series of instructions and functions that guide and direct play. If you don't like the rules, aren't enjoying specific elements of the game, or just don't think a rule works in your specific circumstance, then feel free to change it. If you roll the dice and they give you a result that you don't think is interesting or would move the story in a good direction, you can simply change the result as you wish.

Of course, you don't want to throw out every result you disagree with or weren't expecting. The game's rules exist to forward the story in directions that you couldn't have predicted and encourage storytelling, character growth, and world-building in new and exciting directions. The tension of putting someone's life in the hands of the dice can be thrilling, and it's one of the reasons why we play TTRPGs.

It's impossible to say where the line between keeping and throwing out rules lies for your table. Only you know when you want to play through or when you want to rewrite. It's very reasonable to take a 5 minute break to think about how you want the result to play out.

As a note, just because the game is malleable and changeable does not mean it's beyond criticism. You should not ignore flawed or broken design. **If you find any mechanical problems with the game, please contact us and we'll look into it!**

We've included a setting and corresponding flavor elements with the game. You're free to play with these to the degree you want. If you want to ignore them entirely, modify them to your liking, or just play with your own, then go ahead and do it! There's a few elements that are assumed as part of the setting, however, and will probably be difficult to remove. Blades, Bearers and Titans are all core parts of the story, and the game proceeds as if they are there. If you hack them out, then you will have to find a replacement within your setting in order to make sure the game still works.

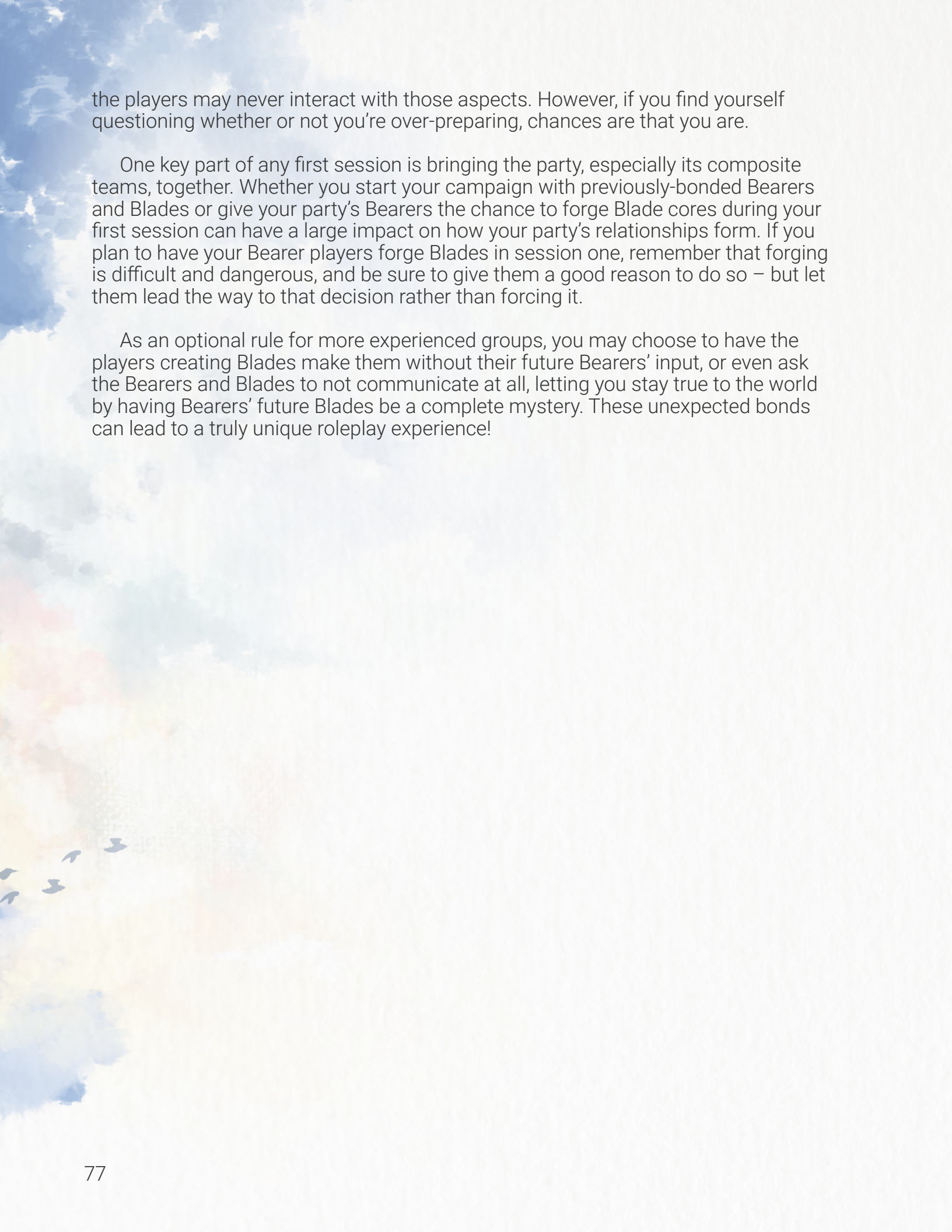
The First Session

Before you start your first session, there's a few things you'll want to discuss at the table. First, establish safety. If you're using any safety tools, make sure that everyone knows and approves of them. After that, discuss as a group the tone, feel, themes, and ideas you all want to explore. Once that's all down, you're free to begin preparing along the lines your players gave you.

Your greatest enemy is going to be over-preparation. Don't create the entire world in advance, because the players are going to create things. Play around them and don't fight against their creations. They write things they're interested in by baking them into their backstories. Not engaging with those stories is wasting some of the most interesting potential your campaign has. They create the first marks on the map, and it's up to you to connect the paths between them. If they have a goal as a character, set them towards it. If they have a destination in mind already, then describe the first leg on that journey.

Of course, you may eventually need to stop and prepare something you did not create in advance. There's no shame in admitting that you need five minutes to put something together. You're only human, and you will craft a better experience when you admit you need a moment to react.

This is not to say you should not prepare anything. Many aspects of your world and its mysteries may well exist outside of the player's actions, even if it means that



the players may never interact with those aspects. However, if you find yourself questioning whether or not you're over-preparing, chances are that you are.

One key part of any first session is bringing the party, especially its composite teams, together. Whether you start your campaign with previously-bonded Bearers and Blades or give your party's Bearers the chance to forge Blade cores during your first session can have a large impact on how your party's relationships form. If you plan to have your Bearer players forge Blades in session one, remember that forging is difficult and dangerous, and be sure to give them a good reason to do so – but let them lead the way to that decision rather than forcing it.

As an optional rule for more experienced groups, you may choose to have the players creating Blades make them without their future Bearers' input, or even ask the Bearers and Blades to not communicate at all, letting you stay true to the world by having Bearers' future Blades be a complete mystery. These unexpected bonds can lead to a truly unique roleplay experience!

Chapter 9: Example Bestiary

The larger one's impact, positive or negative, the more likely one is to acquire foes. Of course, sometimes an enemy is made in a much more straightforward manner, like through an accidental swing at a tavern or a meal eaten too closely to wild animals.

Listed below is a set of example enemies. While you are free to use them as written, they should also serve as a guide to creating your own. After all, much of the combat in *Blades of Ether* will be against Bearers and Blades which you create. Even when it comes to beasts, the Cloud Sea is a vast place, and is home to more ferocious creatures than would be possible to list even in a tome the size of a building. As such, these examples are focused on covering a variety of types of foes you may want to use in your game.

Bestiary

Name	Pack Animal				Role	Other	M	3	I	3
Attacks	1 2 3		Defenses	0 1 2		HP 5 / 5				
Affinities	None				Attributes	Gut				
Notes Pack animals tend to travel in groups. Most encounters utilizing them should have a minimum of three.					Art tags					
					Break					
					Special abilities Howl: Once per combat, this animal may let out a loud cry, bringing two more animals from the same pack running into combat. Only one pack animal may use this ability.					

Name	<i>Elemental Ursine</i>					Role	<i>Other</i>	^M	4	^I	3
Attacks	2 3 4		Defenses	1 2 3		HP 16 / 16					
Affinities	<i>See special abilities</i>				Attributes	<i>Gut, Stamina</i>					
Notes <i>Ursine are afraid of things larger than them and will be hesitant to approach large creatures.</i>					Art tags						
					<i>Unique Elemental Effect</i>						
					Special abilities <i>Elemental Shift: During its turn, this creature may freely change its elemental affinity.</i>						

Name	Novice Bearer			Role	Bearer		M	3	I	2
Attacks	1 1 2		Defenses	0 0 1		HP	5 / 5			
Affinities	Pick one			Attributes	Pick any one or two					
Notes	This Bearer should be roughly equal in strength to a freshly-rolled Bearer made with the Fresh Face guidelines.			Art tags						
				Pick three						
				Special abilities						
				Special Attack: Once in combat, hit a 3x3 square with an attack of 3 (only if their Blade is fighting too)						

Name	Forgeling Blade			Role	Blade	M	1	I	2
Attacks	1 1 2		Defenses	0 0 1		HP 5 / 5			
Affinities	Pick one			Attributes	Pick any one or two				
Notes	This Blade should be roughly equal in strength to a freshly-rolled Blade made with the Fresh Face guidelines.			Art tags					
				Pick three					
				Special abilities					
				Special Attack: Once in combat, hit a 3x3 square with an attack 3 (only if their Bearer is fighting too)					

Name	Blade Eater					Role	Bearer	M	5	I	3
Attacks	2 3 4		Defenses	1 2 2		HP	15 / 15				
Affinities	Pick one to three					Attributes	Pick any one or two				
Notes	The Blade Eater has properties of both a Bearer and Blade, but can be overconfident.					Art tags					
						Unique Elem. Effect, all Reactions					
						Special abilities					
						Radius Hop: Move up to two squares before attacking, then move four more after.					

Name	Legendary Bearer				Role	Bearer		M	4	I	4
Attacks	4 5 7		Defenses	4 5 7		HP	25 / 25				
Affinities	Pick one to three				Attributes	Pick any one or two					
Notes This Bearer should be a challenging boss encounter for a seasoned group.					Art tags						
					Use as many as you'd like						
					Special abilities						
					Talent: Titan Driver						
					Special Attack: Once per combat, attack 8 on a 5x5 area (only if their Blade is conscious)						

Name	Titanic Blade				Role	Blade	M	2	I	5
Attacks	4 5 7		Defenses	4 5 7		HP	25 / 25			
Affinities	Pick two to four				Attributes	Pick any one or two				
Notes This Blade should be a challenging boss encounter for a seasoned group.					Art tags					
					Use as many as you'd like					
					Special abilities					
					Talent: Orbital Death Beam					
					Special Attack: Once per combat, attack 8 on a 5x5 area (only if their Bearer is conscious)					

Name	Rockbart					Role	Other	M	4	I	10
Attacks	6 7 8		Defenses	4 5 6		HP	90 / 90				
Affinities	Earth					Attributes	Might				
Notes The Rockbart is extremely territorial. Parties should expect to treat it as a threat meant to keep them out of areas, an obstacle to sneak around, or a very challenging encounter for end-game players.						Art tags					
						Break, Topple, Launch					
						Special abilities					
						Aggressive Scream: Once per combat, gives all players -1 to all rolls until its next turn.					

Chapter 10: Reference Materials

You've packed your bag, sharpened your blade, and marked your next destination on the map. Now then... Which animal did they say was too dangerous to fight again?

While this chapter contains no new information about *Blades of Ether*, it provides easy-to-access reminders about the game's contents and mechanics so that gameplay doesn't have to grind to a halt when someone says "wait, how does that thing work again?" You'll find an organized set of definitions, reprints of the game's information tables, and printable character sheets and NPC cards so that you can find what you need in the heat of battle!

Terminology

Game Basics

Arc (13): A number of gameplay sessions that together compose one story beat.

Architect (1): Also known as the Game Master, the person in charge of running the game.

Bearer (2): An organic being who has bonded with one or more Blades for life.

Blade (2): An etheric being forged from a gemstone core. Blades need to form bonds with Bearers to manifest bodies.

Non-player character: Any character that no player is in direct control of.

Player: A participant in the game who controls a single Bearer or Blade.

Player character (1): A player's Bearer or Blade.

Party (1): The total group of all player characters.

Party member (1): Any person in the party.

Team (1): A group of a Bearer and all their Blades.

Teammate (1): Any person on one's team.

Partner (1): A Blade's Bearer or one of a Bearer's Blades.

Session (13): One real-life playing of *Blades of Ether*.

Game Mechanics

Dead box (37): A box that, when checked, allows a player to permanently kill their character (reverting Blades to unbonded cores) and temporarily completely control the narrative. Natural Blades must check this box along with their Bearer.

Dice pool (3): The full set of dice rolled for any given check, typically a number of six-sided dice equal to the value of an attribute.

Success (3): A die that lands on 5 or 6.

Success check (3): The number of successes that needs to be beaten to accomplish a task on a given roll. Also simply called the check.

Net successes (3): The number one of successes one has passed a success check by. For example, if a player rolls 4 successes against a success check of 2, they have rolled 2 net successes.

Near hit (3): A roll where the success check is only beaten by one net success. The action succeeds but comes with a drawback.

Near miss (3): A roll with exactly zero net successes. The action fails but comes with an upside.

I'm Really Feeling It (13): An ability all players have: once per arc, before rolling initiative, you may declare

yourself exceptionally motivated for combat. Describe why, then add the most relevant attribute to your initiative dice pool (which can be a second instance of any of the four attributes used in base initiative calculation) and start combat with a free special die showing a six.

It's Reyn Time (13): An ability all players have: once per arc, you may guarantee your success on a roll.

The Heronop Special (14): An ability all players have: once per arc, you may turn a failed roll into a near miss.

Reconciliation burst (11): A special ability that can be used by two players at negative affinity, allowing them a significant boost towards a check or free special attack in combat as they improve their relationship.

Character Components

Idea (7): Four core values: bravery, truth, compassion, and justice. Each idea is represented by certain attributes, elemental affinities, and elemental effects. The attributes in an idea are used in special attacks.

Attribute (7): An aspect of a character that determines their strengths and weaknesses. There are 12 attributes, divided among the four ideas: might, willpower, and calculation represent bravery; gut, experience, and knowledge represent truth; stamina, empathy, and attunement represent compassion; and swiftness, improvisation, and passion represent justice.

Affinity (10): The momentary closeness between two player characters within their bond, ranked between -2 and 2.

Bond (10): A description of the relationship between two player characters.

Bond points (37): Points used to buy character improvements, earned at the end of sessions based on the developing or playing into bonds between characters.

Element (9): The aspects of ether, in pairs sorted under ideas: fire and water correspond with bravery, wind and ice correspond with truth, earth and electricity correspond with compassion, and light and dark correspond with justice.

Elemental affinity (9): The primary element(s) that a Blade, Bearer, or other being is attuned to.

Elemental mastery (14): The field skill automatically granted to any Blade or Bearer with an elemental affinity. It can be used to solve problems and traverse obstacles outside of combat using elemental ether.

Field skill (14): An area in which a player character has an exceptional level of knowledge.

Health Points (9): A value that represents how injured a character can get before they fall unconscious.

Inventory (37): The collection of belongings a player has.

Talent (40): Special actions a character knows how to do or traits inherent to them.

Pair talent (51): A talent that must be taken by both a Bearer and their Blade, and grants effects to both partners.

Archetype Talent (52): A unique talent with a big impact on a character who takes it. Archetype talents grant access to further specialized talents based on the archetype.

Combat

Action (18): Any non-movement task taken on a turn during combat that requires a dice roll, such as attacking or interacting with an element in the environment.

Attack (21): An action that deals damage to a target, including basic attacks, arts, and special attacks.

Basic attack (21): A normal attack that can be performed on any turn.

Art (22): A unique attack that Blades and Bearers can perform. A character's three arts can be customized with tags to have bonuses like boosted damage, greater range, and special effects.

Art cooldown (22): The number of turns until a given art can be used again.

Cooldown die (22): A die used to track an art cooldown.

Art tag (22): A purchasable effect added to an art, making it more powerful or giving it new effects.

Tag category (23): The category into which a given art tag is sorted.

Category Cost (23): The base cost of all tags in a given tag category. The cost of applying a tag to an art is based on the tag's category cost as well as the number of tags that art has from that category.

Other tag (26): A tag that doesn't fit into a tag category.

Fundamentals (23): The tag category including the Potency +1, Healing Potion, and Cooldown -1 tags.

Area of effect (24): The tag category that enables arts to hit multiple targets.

Precise Attack (26): An other tag that prevents area of effect arts from hitting unwanted targets.

Reaction (24): The tag category that gives arts special marshal techniques such as knocking over or pushing enemies.

Break (24): A reaction that leaves its target vulnerable to being toppled or launched.

Launch (24): A reaction that, when used on a broken target, sends them flying.

Topple (24): A reaction that, when used on a broken target, forces them to fall on the ground, leaving them more vulnerable to additional attacks.

Positional (25): The tag category that gives additional dice to arts attack rolls when they hit their target from a certain position relative to the direction the target is facing.

Elemental effect (25): The tag category which grants abilities relating to the user's elemental affinities.

Unique elemental effect (25): A tag that lets an attack choose a special effect corresponding to one of their elemental affinities.

Shared elemental effect (26): A set of four elemental effect tags that are based on the idea pairs of two elements.

Special attack (27): A powerful attack where Blade and Bearer strike as one.

Special points (27): Points that are used to perform special attacks. A special point is awarded whenever damage is dealt.

Special die (27): A die used to track a team's special points. Up to three can be stored, holding up to 18 special points.

Blade radius (19): The current distance a Blade is from their Bearer. On a Blade's turn in combat, they can move

freely about their current radius, and are instead limited in movements between radii.

Combat (17): The state the game goes into when a fight involving players breaks out. In combat, all involved take turns and move based on the grid system.

Damage: The amount of HP to remove as a result of being injured.

Healing: The amount of HP to gain as a result of a health recovery effect.

Defend (21): Reacting to an attack in order to reduce or negate damage.

Grid (17): The field on which combat takes place, divided into even squares.

Grid square (17): One space on the grid, equivalent to one square meter (or yard).

Facing (20): The direction a combatant is facing, which can be any of the cardinal directions on the grid.

Initiative (17): A dice roll used to decide the turn order in combat.

Movement (19): The amount of squares a Bearer can move during their turn, or the amount of times a Blade can change their radius in a turn.

Range (21): The number of squares an attack can reach across. Squares that are diagonally related are actually two squares apart.

Basic attack range (21): the number of squares a character's basic attack can reach across. It can be increased by spending bond points.

Token (17): A representation of a character on the grid, indicating their position and facing.

Trait (9): A set of values for combat derived from other characteristics: Basic attack range, initiative, maximum HP, and movement.

Turn (17): The time in which someone involved in combat is allowed to move and act.

Turn order (17): The list of when each turn will occur, represented by tokens in the corner of the grid.

Unconsciousness (29): The state one falls into when they run out of HP.

World & Lore

Arlest (60): The world of Blades of Ether.

Core (intro): The central component to every Blade.

Cloud Sea (66): The layer of dense clouds that covers the entire surface of Arlest.

Forging (intro): The act in which a Bearer manifests and bonds with a new Blade.

Great Void (intro): The mile-wide gap in the Cloud Sea around the World Tree.

Potential (2): The ability for an organic being to become a Bearer.

Titan (65): A massive, sentient creature that lives on or under the Cloud Sea. Many Titans carry entire societies of humanoids and ecosystems of plants and animals on top of or inside of themselves.

World Tree (65): The unclimbed giant pillar at the center of the Cloud Sea which stretches up further than anyone can measure.

Reference Tables

Character Creation Starting Points				
	Attributes	Field skills	Arts	Talents
	1 point allows you to increase an attribute by 1. Ranks above 4 cost 2 points. Ranks above 8 cost 3 points.	Field skills do not come in tiered rankings, so create the suggested number of skills.	You have a number of tags per art to claim, but can only spend so much in any one category. Taking a tag from the area of effect category counts as 3 tags, and taking the Precise Attack tag counts as 2.	Acquire talents whose total rank equals the number listed below.
Fresh face	8 points	2 field skills	2 tags, max 1/cat.	5 ranks
Part-time hero	16 points	3 field skills	4 tags, max 2/cat.	8 ranks
Veteran	24 points	4 field skills	6 tags, max 2/cat.	11 ranks
Titan savior	32 points	5 field skills	8 tags, max 3/cat.	14 ranks

Art Tags at Character Creation					
Fundamentals Cost 1	Area of Effect Cost 3	Reactions Cost 1	Positionals Cost 1	Elemental Effects Cost 1, requires affinity	Other Cost varies
Potency +1 Max 5	Circle Attack Max 2	Break	Side Advantage Bearers only	Unique Elem. Effect Any element	Range +1 Cost 1 Max 5
Healing Potion	Line Attack	Topple	Rear Advantage Bearers only	Invigorating Steam Fire or water	Precise Attack Cost 2
Cooldown -1 Max 2		Launch	Pincer Attack Blades only	Bitter Snowstorm Wind or ice	
		Stagger		Counter Spike Earth or electricity	
		Rush Max 2		Blinding Eclipse Light or dark	

Upgrade Bond Points Costs	
Attribute	2 × new rank
Elemental affinity	7 × new total number of affinities
Field skill	3 per field skill
Talent	3 × talent rank
Basic attack range	2 × new total bonus range (maximum: 5)
Categorized arts tag	Cat. cost × new number of tags in that category on that art
Other arts tag	Precise Attack: 10; Range +1: 2 × new total bonus range

Art Tags					
Fundamentals Category cost 3	Area of Effect Category cost 15	Reactions Cat. cost 5	Positionals Category cost 3	Elemental Effects Cat. cost 4, requires affinity	Other Cost varies
Potency +1 Max 5	Circle Attack Max 2	Break	Side Advantage Bearers only	Unique Elem. Effect Any element	Range +1 Base cost 2 Max 5
Healing Potion	Line Attack	Topple	Rear Advantage Bearers only	Invigorating Steam Fire or water	Precise Attack Cost 10
Cooldown -1 Max 2		Launch	Pincer Attack Blades only	Bitter Snowstorm Wind or ice	
		Stagger		Counter Spike Earth or electricity	
		Rush Max 2		Blinding Eclipse Light or dark	

Name		Role	M	I
Attacks	Defenses	HP		
Affinities	Attributes			
Notes	Art tags			
	Special abilities			

Name		Role	M	I
Attacks	Defenses	HP		
Affinities	Attributes			
Notes	Art tags			
	Special abilities			

Name		Role	M	I
Attacks	Defenses	HP		
Affinities	Attributes			
Notes	Art tags			
	Special abilities			

Name		Role	M	I
Attacks	Defenses	HP		
Affinities	Attributes			
Notes	Art tags			
	Special abilities			

Blades of Ether

Name		Dead Box ☐
Bond Points	Current	Total
Bearer		Blade
		Circle one

Pronouns	Player
Weapon	Home Titan
Partner	Appearance

Basic Attack Range	HP
Initiative	Movement

Traits

Attributes and Elemental Affinities

Bravery	Truth	Compassion	Justice				
Might	Gut	Stamina	Swiftness				
Willpower	Experience	Empathy	Improvisation				
Calculation	Knowledge	Attunement	Passion				
Fire	Water	Wind	Ice	Earth	Electric	Light	Dark

Field Skills

Bonds

Name	-2	-1	0	1	2
Name	-2	-1	0	1	2
Name	-2	-1	0	1	2
Name	-2	-1	0	1	2
Name	-2	-1	0	1	2

Character creation: Basic attack range = 1. HP = willpower + stamina + 4. Initiative = improvisation + gut or calculation + experience. Movement = 3 for Bearers, 1 for Blades. Bond points costs: Attribute = 2 × new rank. Elem. affinity = 7 × total affinities. Field skill = 3. Talent = 3 × rank. Basic attack range = 2 × total bonus range (max 5). Art tag = category cost × total category tags. Precise Attack = 10. Range +1 = 2 × total bonus range (max 5).

Blades of Ether by Alexis Eva, Kaylee Maya, and Ruby Soleil-Raine. For more information: gears.link/blades

I'm Really Feeling It	☐ A ☐
It's Reyn Time	☐ A ☐
The Heronop Special	☐ A ☐
Special dice	

Art 1	
Description	
Potency +	
Cooldown -	
Range +	

Art 2	
Description	
Potency +	
Cooldown -	
Range +	

Art 3	
Description	
Potency +	
Cooldown -	
Range +	

Talent Description		

Inventory and Notes

Core Dice Mechanics

Rolling Dice: Roll a **Dice Pool** which consists of an Attribute and any relevant bonuses. Any **Successes** (5s or 6s rolled) beyond the **Check** (difficulty) are **Net Successes**.

Dice Roll Results: Just one net success is a **Near Hit**, and victory comes with an unexpected consequence; zero net successes is a **Near Miss**, and failure comes with a small benefit.

Combat Turns

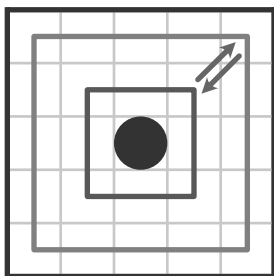
On Your Turn: On your turn in combat, you may **Move**, perform an **Action** (any one dice roll; most often an **Attack**), and freely change the direction you're **Facing**.

Movement

Move from one orthogonal, adjacent square to another. **Diagonal squares** are 2 squares apart. Movement can be split **before and after** an action.

Non-Blades: Move a number of squares per turn equal to your **Movement** trait.

Blades: You can freely move about the squares in your current **Radius** and change radii a number of times equal to your **Movement** trait. **Take -1** in third radius; roll at **half (rounded up)** and move **one square per turn** outside radii.



Distance: If you don't attack, take **double** movement.

Radius Changes: If Bearer moves, choose nearest square in previous radius or **stay in place**, changing radii. If Bearer is moved, **stay in place**.

Facing: You may face any cardinal direction. Choose a **direction** at the end of your turn.

End of Turn Reminders

- ★ Choose Facing.
- ★ If **Blade**, choose a square to stay in.
- ★ Gain a **Special Point** if your basic attack or art hit.
- ★ Turn **Cooldown Dice** 1 lower. 1s turned are removed; art is **ready**.
- ★ Move **Turn Order Token** from top of turn order list to bottom.

Once-Per-Arc Special Abilities

I'm Really Feeling It: Add one **Attribute** to **Initiative** roll, and gain **6 Special Points**.

It's Reyn Time: Guarantee roll **success**.

The Heronop Special: Turn failed roll into **Near Miss**.

Attacking and Defending

Attack: Name a target within your attack's **Range** (distance in squares) and perform a standard dice roll to attack. **Face** your target; they **Face** you after the attack.

Defend: Standard dice roll to defend. Turn to **Face** attacker.

Basic Attack

Range = **Basic Attack Range** trait. Typically no bonuses. Successful attacks grant one **Special Point**.

Art

Range = **1 + Range +1** Art tags. Target might be an **Area of Effect**. **Potency +1** and **Positional** tags grant bonus dice. Beneficial effects apply regardless of range and success. Arts have **Cooldowns**. Successful attacks grant one **Special Point**.

Special Attack

Range = **anywhere**. Higher levels are **Area of Effect**. Each special increases the **Special Level** of the next one. Expend **Special Level × 6 Special Points** to use. Dice pools use **Ideas**; roll **unopposed**. Applies one **Elemental Effect** from elements aligned with the idea.

Special Attack Levels

1: Cost 6. Target **one enemy**; roll chosen idea; apply one aligned elem. effect.

2: Cost 12. Split damage among any enemies in a **3x3 area**; you and your partner **each roll your chosen idea**; apply one aligned elem. effect to all hit.

3: Cost 18. Split among **5x5 area**; **each choose an idea to roll**; apply one elem. effect from either idea to all hit. **Resets Special Level** to 1.

Party Size Special Attack Rules

1 Team: Specials 1 and 2 **do not consume Special Points**.

2 Teams: One team **receives 6 Special Points** when the other uses a Level 2 Special.

3+ Teams: No changes.

Art Tag Effects

- ★ = has important, complex mechanics
- ▲ = has a beneficial effect with a duration
- ▼ = has a detrimental effect with a duration

Fundamentals

Potency +1 (max 5): +1 to attack.

Healing Potion: One ally heals **net successes**.

Cooldown -1 (max 2): Start cooldown Die 1 lower.

Area of Effect

Circle Attack (max 2): Target all enemies in a 3x3 area; lv. 2 for 5x5 area.

Line Attack: Target all enemies in a **straight line 5 + Bonus Range** long.

Reactions

★ ▼ **Break**: Hit target is **Broken**, vulnerable to **Topple and Launch**, until your next turn. Can be extended by whole turn cycles.

★ ▼ **Topple**: Requires and removes **Break**. Target cannot move or attack until your next turn. They can defend, but failed attacks are **Near Hits**. Take an action to un-topple an adjacent ally. **Cannot be extended**.

★ **Launch**: Requires and removes **Break**. Target is pushed **net successes squares** away. Object collision **deals damage = squares from stopping**. Hit combatant takes **damage = squares from stopping**. If no object collision, target moves **back in the turn order** one place.

Stagger: Hit target moves **back in the turn order** one place.

Rush (max 2): Movement +1.

Positionals

Side Advantage (Bearers): Attack from side for +1.

Rear Advantage (Bearers): Attack from behind for +2.

Pincer Attack (Blades): Gain +2 against target in lower radius.

Elemental Effects

Using one requires appropriate **Elemental Affinity**. Pick one of these for **every Special Attack**. Maximum **effect duration** is 6.

★ **Unique Elemental Effect**: choose any one effect corresponding to one of your affinities:

▼ **Fire** (Burning Blade): Target takes 1 damage per turn for **net successes turns**.

▼ **Water** (Arts Seal): Target **cannot use arts** and **do not lower cooldowns** on their next turn.

▲ **Wind** (Blustering Gale): Ally gets +1 defense for **net successes turns**.

▼ **Ice** (Freezing Force): Target **cannot move** next turn. Frozen Bearer = Blade **cannot change radii**.

▲ **Earth** (Cradling Earth): Ally removes and blocks **all detrimental effects** until your next turn.

Electricity (Electrifying Burst): Target moves **back in the turn order** or ally moves **forward in the turn order** one place.

▲ **Light** (Blade of Light): Ally Bearer gains +2 range for **net successes turns**, or ally Blade moves **freely among all radii** with no penalties during their next turn.

▼ **Dark** (Shadow Manipulation): **Redirect enemy attacks** to chosen ally for **net successes turns**.

Invigorating Steam (bravery, fire or water): One ally uses **one art one turn sooner**.

▼ **Bitter Snowstorm** (truth, wind or ice): Target takes -1 **movement** (min 0) and **attack range** (min 1) for **net successes turns**.

▲ **Counter Spike** (compassion, earth or electricity): Anyone who attacks you **takes 1 damage back** for **net successes turns**.

▼ **Blinding Eclipse** (justice, light or dark): Target takes -1 to **attack and defense rolls** until **after your next turn**.

Other Tags

Precise Attack: Detrimental effects **do not hit allies**.

Range +1 (max 5): +1 attack range.

Blades of Ether

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